

# Raghunātha dāsa Gosvāmī

## *A Scholarly-Devotional Biography*

From Saptagrāma to the samādhi at Rādhā-kuṇḍa

Govardhana Pilgrimage Project

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## Editorial Note

This biography was written for devotional reading on pilgrimage while maintaining explicit source controls. The narrative gives priority to Raghunātha's own surviving writings and Caitanya-caritāmṛta, then uses early Vraja devotional historiography, later/local tradition, and documentary evidence at their appropriate levels.

Chronology is intentionally conservative. The twelve-day journey to Purī and the sixteen-year confidential-service period are secure textual anchors. The often-repeated birth year c. 1494/1495 remains approximate. A 1584 Sanskrit death-bed settlement is the strongest fixed late-life horizon, while a 1588 legal record preserves a later transfer in Raghunātha's name; the exact year of his disappearance is therefore left unresolved rather than forced.

The biography does not present Raghunātha's extreme fasting, sleeplessness, or bodily austerity as a regimen for imitation. Its central interpretive thread is relationship: Haridāsa, Nityānanda, Mahāprabhu, Svarūpa, Rūpa, Sanātana, Govardhana, Rādhā-kuṇḍa, and ultimately Rādhā-dāsyā.

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## A Child in the House of Twelve Lakhs

*Wealth, inheritance, Haridāsa Ṭhākura, and the first quiet movement toward Śrī Caitanya*

Raghunātha dāsa Gosvāmī entered the world inside a house of almost unimaginable abundance. Long before he became the gaunt ascetic of Rādhā-kuṇḍa, living on almost nothing and measuring his days in nāma, remembrance, service and tears, he was the son of Govardhana Majumadāra and the nephew of Hirāṇya Majumadāra, two brothers whose wealth and influence were famous in the Saptagrāma region of Bengal. Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja introduces them without embarrassment: they were men of great aiśvarya, social standing and religious reputation. The future renunciant did not grow up at the margins of society. He grew up at its prosperous center.

The figure Kṛṣṇadāsa gives is deliberately memorable: Hirāṇya and Govardhana were “masters of twelve lakhs of coins” at Saptagrāma. In the translation tradition this is explained as an annual revenue or income of 1,200,000 rupees. Whatever exact economic comparison one might make with a later age, the literary point is unmistakable. Raghunātha was the heir of a household in which wealth was not occasional comfort but an organizing fact of life—land, revenue, dependents, servants, political responsibilities, religious patronage and the expectations attached to a powerful family.

Yet Kṛṣṇadāsa does not paint that household as simply worldly or corrupt. The two brothers are described as generous, respectful of brāhmaṇical culture, well behaved, aristocratic and prominent among religious men. They supported brāhmaṇas of Nadia with money, land and even villages. This matters. Raghunātha’s later renunciation was not a flight from a caricature of wicked parents into holiness. He was born into a family that could recognize saintliness, give in charity and maintain respected Vaiṣṇava teachers. His struggle would be subtler: how does someone whose heart belongs elsewhere live faithfully inside a world that is not merely evil, but good in many recognizable ways and yet cannot hold him?

Later Gauḍīya biographical tradition locates the family home at Śrī-Kṛṣṇapura near Ādi-Saptagrāma and places Raghunātha’s birth approximately in 1416 Śaka, around 1494–1495 CE. That dating is a reconstruction, not a date stated by Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja. More secure than the exact year is the social world preserved in the early narrative: Govardhana was his father; Hirāṇya his powerful uncle; Balarāma Ācārya served as priest in the household circle; Yadunandana Ācārya would become Raghunātha’s spiritual guide. The boy who would one day abandon estates, guards, prestige and inheritance did not first meet devotion after leaving home. It was already woven through the life he inherited.

One of the earliest scenes in which we can actually see the young Raghunātha takes place not in his family mansion but nearby, in Cāndapura. Haridāsa Ṭhākura came there and stayed under the care of Balarāma Ācārya. Kṛṣṇadāsa says that Haridāsa lived in a solitary leaf-thatched cottage, absorbed in kīrtana, while accepting his alms or prasāda through Balarāma’s household. It is a small scene, almost hidden inside the much larger life of Haridāsa. But for Raghunātha’s biography it is decisive.

At that time Raghunātha was still a bālaka—a boy—and was engaged in study. The text does not yet present him as a runaway, a fasting renunciant or a public servant of Caitanya. He is simply a student who goes to see Haridāsa Ṭhākura. The distance between the two worlds could hardly be greater. On one side stood a family whose wealth was measured in lakhs, whose influence extended

through land and revenue. On the other sat Haridāsa in a solitary cottage, chanting. And the boy kept going to him.

Kṛṣṇadāsa does not tell us the details of their conversations. We are not given a remembered sermon, a secret mantra or an elaborate initiation scene. Instead he gives something more restrained and, in a way, more powerful: Haridāsa showed mercy to the boy. Then Kṛṣṇadāsa adds an interpretive sentence that reaches across Raghunātha's entire life—"that mercy became a cause of his attaining Caitanya." The seed of the later story is thus not Raghunātha's own heroism. It is kṛpā.

This changes how his biography should be read. It is easy to admire Raghunātha as the man who repeatedly escaped from guards, crossed Bengal almost without food, gave up dependence on his wealthy family, stood at the Simha-dvāra, ate rejected rice, worshiped the Govardhana-śilā and finally settled at Rādhā-kuṇḍa. But the earliest narrative logic places mercy before achievement. Before he renounced anything, someone had shown him grace. Before he reached Śrī Caitanya, Haridāsa's mercy had already become one of the causes leading him there.

There is also a quiet continuity between the young boy at Haridāsa's cottage and the old Gosvāmī at Rādhā-kuṇḍa. Haridāsa's life was organized around the holy name; Raghunātha's mature life would become almost unimaginably concentrated around nāma, remembrance and service. Haridāsa lived with very little; Raghunātha would eventually reduce his own dependence on possessions and food far beyond ordinary measure. Yet the point is not that Raghunātha copied Haridāsa outwardly. His later renunciation would have its own history, and Mahāprabhu Himself would first forbid him from making a show of premature vairāgya. The deeper inheritance was another one: devotion can become so central that the ordinary measures of security, prestige and possession begin to lose their final authority.

Years later, when Raghunātha looked back upon his life in his own Gaurāṅga-stava-kalpavṛkṣa, he described the wealth of his youth with startling language. Gaurāṅga, he said, had lifted him from the "forest fire of immense wealth," placed him with Svarūpa Dāmodara, and given him the guñjā garland and Govardhana-śilā. The phrase does not mean that money itself was simply evil. It tells us what that world had become to Raghunātha from the inside: something enormous, blazing, difficult to escape, and incapable of giving what his heart required.

But that insight belongs to the man at the far end of the story. The child could not yet see all that would follow. He did not yet know Pānihāṭi, the twelve-day road to Purī, Svarūpa Dāmodara's embrace, the touch of Mahāprabhu's hands on Govardhana-śilā, or the banks of Rādhā-kuṇḍa. He knew a prosperous household, his studies, the religious world of his family—and nearby, a solitary Vaiṣṇava whose life was given to the holy name.

So the first movement of Raghunātha's life is not an escape. It is an attraction. Before he runs from home, he goes toward Haridāsa. Before the gates, guards and roads enter the story, there is darśana. Before the spectacular renunciation for which the world remembers him, there is the almost invisible mercy of a Vaiṣṇava falling upon a boy.

The house of twelve lakhs gave Raghunātha one inheritance. Haridāsa Ṭhākura quietly opened the way to another.

## At Śāntipura

*Longing, restraint, and the education of renunciation*

The mercy of Haridāsa Ṭhākura did not make Raghunātha's outward life simpler. It made his inward life harder to ignore. Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja says plainly that from childhood Raghunātha was udāsa toward viṣaya—indifferent to material enjoyment. Yet he remained the son of Govardhana Majumadāra, heir to a household that could surround him with every comfort, every responsibility and every reason to remain. His longing did not arise because there was nothing for him at home. It arose despite there being almost everything.

The first direct meeting with Śrī Caitanya came after the Lord accepted sannyāsa and returned for a time to Śāntipura. Raghunātha came there and fell at Mahāprabhu's feet, overwhelmed with love. Kṛṣṇadāsa describes the Lord responding not with a discourse but with touch: out of mercy, Mahāprabhu touched Raghunātha with His feet. The family connection mattered here too. Govardhana had long served Advaita Ācārya, and through Advaita's favor Raghunātha received Mahāprabhu's remnants and remained near the Lord for several days.

For five or seven days, Kṛṣṇadāsa says, he had the sight and service of those feet. Then Mahāprabhu departed for Nīlācala. Raghunātha went home—and something in him no longer knew how to live as before. The text says he became premete pāgala, “mad in love.” Again and again he tried to leave for Jagannātha Purī. Again and again his father had him brought back.

The household responded as powerful households respond when an only heir begins disappearing down the road. Five watchmen guarded him day and night. Four personal servants remained with him. Two brāhmaṇas attended to his food. Eleven people in all were assigned to keep him continuously under control. The arrangement tells us two things at once. His family was determined not to lose him. And his longing was serious enough that ordinary persuasion had failed.

This is the first place where the later image of Raghunātha as an unstoppable renunciant can mislead us. He did not immediately succeed. He wanted to go. He tried. He was caught. He was guarded. He was unhappy. For a long stretch of his early life, devotion did not appear as triumphant freedom but as frustrated longing.

Then Mahāprabhu came again to Śāntipura. This was a later visit, after the Lord had set out toward Vṛndāvana with a vast following and then turned back. When Raghunātha heard that He was nearby, he pleaded with his father for permission to go: “Let me see the Lord's feet; otherwise life will not remain in my body.” Govardhana relented, but not without precautions. He sent his son with servants and provisions and told him to return quickly.

Raghunātha remained with Mahāprabhu at Śāntipura for seven days. Day and night his mind circled around one question: how could he escape the hands of the guards and go with the Lord to Nīlācala? He was standing in the presence of the person for whom he had tried repeatedly to abandon home, and yet even there he was thinking in terms of flight—how to break free, how to make the decisive move, how to end the contradiction all at once.

Mahāprabhu answered the desire beneath the words before Raghunātha spoke it aloud. Kṛṣṇadāsa introduces the instruction as āśvāsa-vacana—words of reassurance. That is important. The Lord was not rejecting his longing. He was disciplining it.

“Be steady and go home,” Mahāprabhu told him. “Do not become vātula—wild, frantic, unbalanced. Gradually a person reaches the far shore of the ocean of material existence.” Then came the sentence that would govern the next stage of Raghunātha’s life: “Do not practice markāṭa-vairāgya for people to see. Accept what is appropriate in the material sphere without attachment.”

Markāṭa-vairāgya literally evokes the renunciation of a monkey: outwardly naked, apparently possessing nothing, while inwardly the life of appetite continues. In later Gauḍīya explanation the expression becomes a warning against renunciation that is external, theatrical or premature. Mahāprabhu did not tell Raghunātha that vairāgya was unnecessary. He told the future emblem of vairāgya that renunciation had to become true before it became visible.

The next instruction is even more exact: antare niṣṭhā kara, bāhye loka-vyavahāra—“make firmness within; outwardly conduct yourself in ordinary human dealings.” The sentence divides Raghunātha’s life into an inner and outer discipline. Inside: niṣṭhā, unwavering orientation. Outside: loka-vyavahāra, the conduct required to live among people. The two are not hypocrisy. They are obedience.

Mahāprabhu also gave him hope. After returning from Vṛndāvana to Nīlācala, the Lord said, Raghunātha could come by some pretext. But even the means of escape was not to be manufactured by force. “At that time Kṛṣṇa will reveal the means to you. If Kṛṣṇa bestows mercy upon someone, who can keep him back?” The timing of liberation was placed not in Raghunātha’s ingenuity but in grace.

This is one of the decisive reversals in his biography. Until now, Raghunātha had interpreted sincerity largely as leaving. Mahāprabhu now asked him to prove sincerity by staying. The boy who had repeatedly run toward Purī was told to walk back into the same household, the same wealth, the same expectations, the same family eyes—and not pretend that inner freedom depended upon changing his clothes or his address.

Kṛṣṇadāsa is explicit that Raghunātha obeyed. He returned home and practiced Mahāprabhu’s instruction. He abandoned bāhya-vairāgya, external renunciation, and the frantic behavior that had accompanied it. He performed the duties appropriate to his position without attachment. Antya-līlā later summarizes the transformation in an almost paradoxical phrase: he became viṣayi-prāya—he looked almost like a worldly man. Inside, however, vairāgya remained.

His parents were relieved. From the outside it appeared that the crisis had passed. Their son was functioning. He carried out responsibilities. He no longer continually staged his desire to flee. The guards could loosen their fear. The wealthy heir seemed to have returned to the world that belonged to him.

But Mahāprabhu had not taught him to forget. He had taught him how to wait.

That waiting would become its own sādhana. Before Raghunātha learned how to leave everything, he had to learn how not to be owned by the things he had not yet left. Before the outer renunciation came the inner separation. Before the road opened, he had to become steady enough that when Kṛṣṇa finally revealed the way, he could walk it without looking back.

## The Businessman's Year

*Arrest, diplomacy, and the freedom no rope could hold*

Mahāprabhu had told Raghunātha to return home, remain steady, and let inward renunciation grow beneath ordinary outward conduct. Raghunātha obeyed so thoroughly that, to those watching him, he almost seemed to have become the person his family wanted him to be. Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja says he became viṣayi-prāya—outwardly almost like a worldly man. Inside was vairāgya; outside he performed the work before him.

That sentence is easy to read as a temporary disguise, as though the only real Raghunātha were the future ascetic and everything before his escape were theater. The next episode makes that reading too simple. Raghunātha did not merely look occupied. He became effective inside the difficult world of his family's affairs. When danger entered through money, government claims, rivalry and arrest, the young man who longed to abandon everything proved capable of understanding people and resolving a conflict that older men had failed to settle.

The dispute began around the revenue administration of Saptagrāma. Kṛṣṇadāsa describes a Muslim caudhurī, an official connected with tax collection, whose position had been displaced when Hiraṇya dāsa—Raghunātha's uncle—took the area under a revenue agreement. The numbers in the text are enormous. Hiraṇya collected twenty lakhs and delivered twelve lakhs to the ruler. The dispossessed caudhurī received nothing and became his rival. Whatever the exact fiscal mechanism behind these figures, Kṛṣṇadāsa's narrative is clear about the result: money had become grievance, and grievance had acquired governmental force.

The caudhurī submitted an account to the authorities and brought in the minister responsible. He intended to arrest Hiraṇya, but Hiraṇya had already left. So the official seized Raghunātha instead.

The situation was no longer the sheltered frustration of guards at home. Raghunātha was now being held because of a political and financial quarrel involving his family. Day after day the caudhurī threatened him: bring your father and your uncle, or you will be punished. At moments he intended to beat him. Yet Kṛṣṇadāsa says that whenever he looked at Raghunātha, his mind changed and he could not strike.

The text adds a social detail that should not be romanticized but should not be ignored. The official feared him partly because he knew him as a kāyastha of an influential family. Raghunātha was not socially powerless. The same world of birth, status and administrative culture from which he inwardly wished to become free could still protect him. The official could threaten loudly, but he hesitated to use violence.

Raghunātha did not answer the danger with defiance. Nor did he denounce wealth, taxation or government as beneath him. Instead he studied the person standing before him and changed the relationship in which the quarrel was being understood.

“My father and my uncle are your brothers,” he told the caudhurī. Brothers quarrel, and brothers become affectionate again; who can say which condition will last? Today there is conflict. Tomorrow the three of you may sit together in peace.



Then Raghunātha made the argument personal. Just as I am my father’s son, he said, so I am also your boy. I am your pālya, one to be protected and maintained; you are my pālaka, my protector and maintainer. How is it proper for a maintainer to punish the one who depends upon him? And then, with a kind of audacity made gentle by humility, he praised the man threatening him as learned in scripture and “like a living pīr.”

It was diplomacy built from relationship rather than accusation. Raghunātha did not tell the caudhurī that he was wrong to desire a share. He did not defend every decision made by his uncle. He gave the man a more honorable identity in which to act: not enemy, but elder; not jailer, but protector; not merely claimant, but someone capable of saintly conduct.

The effect was immediate. Kṛṣṇadāsa says the caudhurī’s heart softened. Tears ran down his beard. The man who had threatened punishment told Raghunātha, “From today you are my son. Today, by some means, I shall have you released.” He spoke with the minister, secured Raghunātha’s freedom, and then explained his grievance with new openness.

The official said that Raghunātha’s uncle was enjoying eight lakhs and that, as a shareholder, he too ought to receive something. Then he entrusted the settlement to the very young man he had just held: arrange a meeting between us; let your uncle decide what is proper; I will depend upon his judgment.

Raghunātha did exactly that. He brought his uncle and the caudhurī together. The dispute was settled. “Everything became peaceful,” Kṛṣṇadāsa says.

The episode reveals a side of Raghunātha that disappears easily beneath the brilliance of his later renunciation. He could negotiate. He could read motive. He could speak across religious and political difference without surrendering dignity. He could transform hostility through humility without becoming weak. And he could work within systems of land, money and authority while remaining inwardly detached from the life those systems promised him.

Kṛṣṇadāsa then gives the period an unexpected duration: “In this way one year of Raghunātha passed.” The standard translation calls him during that year a first-class business manager. The Bengali itself is sparer, but the narrative justifies the impression. For a year, Mahāprabhu’s command to live outwardly in ordinary dealings was not theoretical. Raghunātha inhabited it.

There is a temptation to treat that year as wasted time between the “real” spiritual events—Śāntipura behind him, Pānihāṭi ahead. But it may be one of the clearest demonstrations of what Mahāprabhu had asked from him. Raghunātha learned that detachment did not require incompetence. He could handle money without belonging to money. He could protect the interests of his household without imagining that the household was his final shelter. He could act fully in a world from which his heart was already withdrawing.

Then the next year came, and the desire to leave returned with force. One night he rose alone and fled. His father caught him at a distant place and brought him back. Then it happened again. And again. The cycle became so persistent that his mother, exhausted by it, proposed the obvious solution: their son had become bātula—mad. Tie him with ropes.

Govardhana’s answer is one of the most revealing speeches in the whole early biography. He had finally understood something that wealth, marriage, affection and surveillance had all failed to change. His son possessed opulence like Indra, he said, and a wife beautiful like a celestial woman—

yet none of it had been able to bind his mind. How then could ropes do what all that splendor could not? Even a father cannot cancel what has ripened in another person's destiny.

Then Govardhana named what he believed had actually happened: Caitanyacandra had bestowed mercy upon his son. "Who can keep at home one who has become mad for Caitanyacandra?"

The words mark a change in the family drama. Earlier, Govardhana had tried to keep Raghunātha because he could not understand why such a life should be abandoned. Now he still wanted his son home, but he had begun to recognize that the force drawing him away did not belong to ropes, persuasion, luxury or fear. The father who could command guards had reached the limit of command.

Raghunātha had learned how to remain. Now the time was approaching when grace would teach him how to leave.

## Pānihāṭi

*Nityānanda's "punishment" and the door to freedom*

Govardhana Majumadāra had finally admitted what his guards had not understood: Caitanyacandra's mercy could not be tied with rope. The next verse in Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja's narrative is almost startling in its simplicity. Raghunātha thought deeply about something, and the next day he went to Nityānanda Gosāñi.

He had tried repeatedly to reach Mahāprabhu by running. He had learned to remain at home by Mahāprabhu's order. He had negotiated danger, lived outwardly among money and responsibility, and still found that the final passage to Nīlācala would not open. Now the direction of his longing shifted. Instead of another escape attempt, he went to Nityānanda.

At Pānihāṭi, on the bank of the Gaṅgā, he found Nityānanda surrounded by kīrtana singers, servants and devotees. The Lord sat beneath a tree upon a raised stone platform, and Kṛṣṇadāsa says He appeared as brilliant as hundreds of thousands of rising suns. People crowded around Him on the ground. Raghunātha, seeing the power of that assembly, remained at a distance and fell flat in obeisance.

A servant pointed him out. Nityānanda heard that Raghunātha had arrived and immediately turned mercy into play. "Thief!" He called. "Now you have shown yourself. Come here, come here. Today I shall punish you."

Even when summoned, Raghunātha hesitated to approach. Nityānanda had him brought near and placed His feet upon Raghunātha's head. The punishment had already begun, and it looked like grace.

Kṛṣṇadāsa does not stop to explain exactly why Nityānanda chose the word corā—"thief." The root narrative leaves the joke alive. Later Gauḍīya tradition often interprets it as affectionate accusation: Raghunātha had been trying to obtain Gaurāṅga while remaining at a distance from Nityānanda, as though stealing the treasure without first receiving the mercy of the one who freely gives it. That is a later devotional explanation, not the grammar of the verse itself. What Kṛṣṇadāsa does make explicit is Nityānanda's mood: He was naturally merciful and playful.

"You stay far away instead of coming near," Nityānanda told him. "Now that I have caught you, I shall punish you. Feed all My associates yogurt and chipped rice." Raghunātha's response was immediate joy.

The heir of Saptagrāma suddenly found a use for wealth that did not bind him. He sent his men into the village to purchase chipped rice, yogurt, milk, sweets, sugar, bananas and other ingredients. When news of the feast spread, brāhmaṇas, respectable villagers, scholars, priests and Vaiṣṇavas poured toward the riverbank. The crowd kept growing, so Raghunātha sent for more supplies from surrounding villages and brought hundreds of earthen pots.

Two preparations dominated the feast. One portion of the chipped rice was mixed with yogurt, sugar and bananas. Another was soaked in hot milk and enriched with condensed milk, banana, sugar, ghee and camphor. The details matter because Kṛṣṇadāsa wants the reader to see abundance—an abundance very different from the private luxury Raghunātha had been trying to escape. Here wealth became prasāda, hospitality and service.

Nityānanda sat on the raised platform with His principal associates around Him. Others sat below, along the riverbank, and eventually even in the shallow water because there was no more room. Everyone received two pots: one of chipped rice with yogurt, one with milk. The whole bank of the Gaṅgā became a vast outdoor feast.

Rāghava Paṇḍita arrived carrying preparations he had already cooked and offered. Seeing Nityānanda feasting elsewhere, he laughed in astonishment. Nityānanda told him that He would eat there during the day and at Rāghava's home at night. Then He explained His delight in the scene with words that turned the Gaṅgā bank into Vraja: "I belong to a community of cowherd boys. I am happy when we eat together in a picnic like this on the sandy bank."

The memory of Vraja then entered the feast explicitly. Once everyone had been served, Kṛṣṇadāsa says that Nityānanda, in meditation, brought Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu. The two brothers moved among the groups. Nityānanda took morsels from the pots and jokingly placed them into Mahāprabhu's mouth; Mahāprabhu smiled, returned the gesture and fed Nityānanda. Most people could not understand what Nityānanda was doing. A few fortunate devotees, Kṛṣṇadāsa says, could see Mahāprabhu there.

Then Nityānanda gave Mahāprabhu a place beside Him, and the two brothers ate together. "Hari! Hari!" filled the riverbank. As the devotees ate and chanted, they remembered Kṛṣṇa and Balarāma taking meals with the cowherd boys on the bank of the Yamunā. The feast had become more than charity and more than punishment. It was a līlā in which service, remembrance and mercy converged.

The day did not end there. That evening at Rāghava Paṇḍita's temple, Nityānanda led kīrtana and dancing. Kṛṣṇadāsa again says that Mahāprabhu came to watch Nityānanda's dance, visible to Nityānanda though hidden from others. At supper, a place was set on Nityānanda's right. Mahāprabhu came and sat there, and Rāghava served the two brothers together.

Raghunātha himself did not force his way into the center of these visions. Rāghava Paṇḍita gave him something quieter and more intimate: the remnants from the dishes of the two brothers. "Caitanya Gosāñi has eaten this," Rāghava told him. "If you receive His remnants, your bondage will be broken."

The following morning Raghunātha returned beneath the same tree. This time he did not merely offer obeisance from a distance. He worshiped Nityānanda's feet and, through Rāghava Paṇḍita, placed his real desire before Him.

He did not ask for money, protection or status. He called himself fallen and unqualified and confessed the failure of every previous attempt. "Like a dwarf who wants to catch the moon," he said, "I have tried again and again, but I have not succeeded." Each time he had tried to abandon home, his parents had restrained him. Then he stated what he had finally understood: "Without Your mercy, no one can attain Caitanya. If You are merciful, even the lowest person can attain Him."

This is the decisive change from the earlier escape attempts. Raghunātha no longer asks only, "How can I get away?" He asks, "How can I receive mercy?" The obstacle is no longer merely a guard at the gate. The missing passage is grace.

He asked Nityānanda to place His feet upon his head and bless him so that he might attain Mahāprabhu without impediment. Nityānanda smiled and turned to the devotees. Raghunātha's

material happiness, He said, was equal to Indra's, yet because Mahāprabhu had shown him mercy he took no pleasure in it. Nityānanda asked everyone present to bless him.

Then came a prophecy so precise that it gives Pānihāṭi its place at the center of Raghunātha's biography. Nityānanda called him near, placed His feet upon his head, and explained what the feast had accomplished. Because Raghunātha had arranged the picnic on the riverbank, Gaurāṅga had come there to show him mercy. He had eaten the chipped rice and milk, watched the dancing, and taken supper. "Gaurāṅga came personally to deliver you," Nityānanda said. "All the impediments of your bondage are gone."

Then He described what had not yet happened: Mahāprabhu would accept Raghunātha and entrust him to Svarūpa Dāmodara. He would be kept as an antaraṅga-bhṛtya, an intimate servant, at Mahāprabhu's feet.

Everything that Raghunātha had been trying to force was now spoken as something already prepared by mercy. Nityānanda even gave him the same instruction Mahāprabhu had given earlier in another form: go home. But now the sentence had changed. "Return without anxiety. Very soon, without impediment, you will attain Caitanya's feet."

Raghunātha obeyed again. Before leaving, he arranged offerings for Nityānanda's associates and entrusted gifts through Rāghava Paṇḍita. The money of Saptagrāma, which once defined the life he feared being trapped inside, passed quietly into Vaiṣṇava service. Then he took the dust of Rāghava's feet and returned home.

Kṛṣṇadāsa closes the Pānihāṭi unit by saying that Raghunātha considered himself fulfilled because he had received Nityānanda's mercy.

He was not free yet. He still went back through the doors of the family estate. Guards still watched him. But something fundamental had changed. Until Pānihāṭi he had been trying to escape bondage. After Pānihāṭi, Nityānanda told him the bondage had already been cut.

The road to Purī would open soon.

## The Road No One Was Watching

*Yadunandana Ācārya, the final escape, and twelve days to Purī*

Nityānanda had told Raghunātha to go home without anxiety because the impediments were already broken. Raghunātha returned. Outwardly, almost nothing had changed. The family estate still stood around him. The watchmen were still there. The road to Nīlācala was still watched. Yet from the day he returned from Pānihāṭi, he stopped entering the inner quarters of the house and began sleeping outside on the Durgā-maṇḍapa.

The change was small enough to escape drama but large enough to matter. Raghunātha had moved to the edge of the household. He was still home, but no longer fully inside it. The guards stayed awake nearby, and he continued thinking of ways to escape. Meanwhile the well-known Vaiṣṇavas of Bengal were preparing to go to Jagannātha Purī. He could not simply join them. Their party was too visible; if he traveled with famous devotees, his family’s men would find him at once.

So he waited again.

Then, near the end of one night, when only four daṇḍas remained before dawn—about an hour and a half in conventional reckoning—Yadunandana Ācārya entered the courtyard.

This was not a stranger appearing conveniently in the story. Kṛṣṇadāsa pauses to identify him carefully. Yadunandana was Raghunātha’s guru and family priest. He had received the mercy of Vāsudeva Datta, was an intimate disciple of Advaita Ācārya, and by Advaita’s order regarded Śrī Caitanya as the treasure of his life. Years later Raghunātha himself would remember Yadunandana in Vilāpa-kusumāñjali as the guru who bathed him in incomparable mercy.

But on this night Yadunandana came for something entirely ordinary: a problem of Deity service.

One of his brāhmaṇa disciples had been serving the Deity and had stopped. Yadunandana wanted Raghunātha to persuade him to return. Raghunātha rose, offered daṇḍavats to his guru, and went out with him. By then the watchmen, who had been alert night after night, had fallen asleep.

Nothing in the scene resembled a planned rescue. No secret messenger had arrived from Purī. No band of devotees waited outside. No door was broken. His guru simply needed help restoring a neglected service, and because Raghunātha was going with his guru, the household guards had no reason to stop him.

They walked together. Halfway along the road, Raghunātha spoke at Yadunandana’s feet: “I will go to that brāhmaṇa, persuade him and send him to your house. You can return home without worry. Following your order, I will take care of it.” He asked permission. Yadunandana agreed and turned back.

Only then did Raghunātha recognize what had happened.

No servant was beside him. No guard was following. The road had opened without his forcing it. “This is the best opportunity for me to go,” he thought.

He turned east and walked quickly. Then he looked back. No one was there.

The gesture is one of the most human details in the whole story. After years of attempted escape, capture and surveillance, freedom was so unfamiliar that he checked behind him. Still no one came.

Then he did something that explains why the search party would fail. Thinking of the feet of Śrī Caitanya and Nityānanda, he abandoned the main road and took an upapatha, a path not generally used. He left the routes passing from village to village and moved through wooded country, keeping Caitanya’s feet in mind with body, mind and words.

The first day he covered fifteen krośas—rendered in the standard translation as about thirty miles. At evening he stopped in the cowshed of a milkman. The man saw that the traveler had been fasting and gave him milk. Raghunātha drank it and lay down there for the night.

Back at Saptagrāma, the disappearance was finally discovered. The guards went to Yadunandana Ācārya, who told them that Raghunātha had asked permission and, as far as he knew, returned home. Then the household erupted: “Raghunātha has escaped.”

Govardhana assumed that his son must have joined the Bengal Vaiṣṇavas traveling to Purī. Ten men were sent after that party, together with a letter asking Śivānanda Sena to return his son. The men caught the Vaiṣṇavas at Jhāṅkarā. Śivānanda gave them the answer they did not expect: Raghunātha was not with him.

The search party had followed the obvious road. Raghunātha had not.

At dawn after his first night away, he altered his direction again. Having initially gone east, he turned south. He crossed Chatrabhoga and continued through lesser roads from village to village. Kṛṣṇadāsa gives no romantic account of a heroic wilderness pilgrimage. The details are sparse and bodily: walking, hunger, whatever food happened to appear. Sometimes Raghunātha chewed fried grain. Sometimes he cooked something. Sometimes he received milk. The journey was organized around one thought—reaching the feet of Śrī Caitanya.

Twelve days after leaving home, he reached Śrī Puruṣottama, Jagannātha Purī. Kṛṣṇadāsa adds one stark measure of the journey: during those twelve days, Raghunātha ate on only three.

The long history of attempted escape ended without a triumphant entrance.

Mahāprabhu was sitting with His associates, Svarūpa Dāmodara among them. Raghunātha came into the courtyard but stayed at a distance. Thin, dirty from travel and nearly exhausted, he fell flat on the ground.

Mukunda Datta noticed him first. “Here is Raghunātha.”

Mahāprabhu heard the name and called him forward: “Come.” Raghunātha reached Him and seized His feet. Mahāprabhu stood up and embraced him.

The boy who had first come to Śāntipura, the heir guarded by eleven men, the negotiator in the revenue dispute, the “thief” punished by Nityānanda, the fugitive who kept looking behind him on an empty road—all of those movements ended in an embrace.

The devotees, led by Svarūpa Dāmodara, then embraced him too when they saw the mercy Mahāprabhu had shown.

Mahāprabhu interpreted the whole journey in a single sentence: kṛṣṇa-kṛpā baliṣṭha sabā haite —“Kṛṣṇa’s mercy is stronger than everything.” It was that mercy, He said, that had pulled Raghunātha out of the pit of material enjoyment.

Raghunātha answered only within his mind. “I do not know Kṛṣṇa. This I accept: Your mercy has pulled me out.”

Mahāprabhu then spoke in deliberately severe language about the world Raghunātha had left behind. Earlier Kṛṣṇadāsa had praised Govardhana and Hiraṇya as generous, religious patrons of brāhmaṇas; here Mahāprabhu distinguishes that piety from pure Vaiṣṇava detachment. They were charitable and almost Vaiṣṇavas, He said, but attachment to material enjoyment could still make a person blind. The point was not to erase their good qualities. It was to name the particular bondage from which Raghunātha had been delivered.

Then Mahāprabhu looked at the condition of his body. Twelve days of hard travel and little food had left him thin and soiled. The Lord’s heart softened, and He turned to Svarūpa Dāmodara.

At Pānihāṭī, Nityānanda had already foretold this moment: “He will entrust you to Svarūpa.” Now the words became visible.

“This Raghunātha I entrust to you,” Mahāprabhu said. “Accept him as your son or servant.”

There were already several devotees named Raghunātha among Mahāprabhu’s followers, so the Lord gave this one a new relational name: “From today he is Svarūpera Raghu—the Raghu of Svarūpa.”

The gesture was made physically. Mahāprabhu took Raghunātha’s hand and placed it in Svarūpa Dāmodara’s hand. Svarūpa accepted the order and embraced him again.

The escape was complete only when Raghunātha was given away.

He had spent years trying to become free from possession—family expectation, wealth, guards, social identity. Yet at Purī, freedom did not end in independence. Mahāprabhu placed him under someone’s care. Raghunātha did not emerge from the household as a solitary ascetic answerable to no one. He emerged as Svarūpa’s Raghu.

Nityānanda had promised that the bonds would break. Yadunandana had unknowingly walked him beyond the sleeping guards. The unused road had carried him south. Mahāprabhu’s embrace had received him. And Svarūpa’s hand now held his.

The next stage of Raghunātha’s life would be learned there.



## Svarūpera Raghu

### *The instruction he lived*

Mahāprabhu had placed Raghunātha’s hand into Svarūpa Dāmodara’s hand. The years of trying to reach Purī were over. What remained was to learn how to live there.

Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja begins the next movement with a sentence of tenderness: “I cannot describe Caitanya’s affection for His devotees.” Seeing what the journey had done to Raghunātha’s body, Mahāprabhu turned immediately to Govinda, His personal servant. Raghunātha had fasted and undergone hardship on the road, He said; for some days, take good care of him and see that he is nourished.

The first instruction was therefore not austerity. It was care.

Mahāprabhu told Raghunātha to bathe in the sea, see Lord Jagannātha, return, and eat. Raghunātha obeyed. He went to the ocean, bathed, stood before Jagannātha, and came back to Govinda. Govinda then placed before him the remnants of Mahāprabhu’s own meal. Raghunātha accepted them with joy.

For five days he remained at Svarūpa Dāmodara’s feet while Govinda continued to bring him Mahāprabhu’s prasāda. Nothing in those first days resembles self-punishment. Raghunātha had arrived exhausted; Mahāprabhu saw the exhaustion and arranged nourishment. The man who would later become famous for astonishing austerity first entered his renounced life by receiving food from another’s hand.

On the sixth day, Raghunātha stopped accepting the plate Govinda brought.

After the puṣpa-añjali ceremony at Jagannātha’s temple, he began standing at the Simha-dvāra, the Lion Gate, waiting for alms. The servants connected with Jagannātha’s service would return home at night. When they saw a Vaiṣṇava standing there in need of food, they might arrange something for him from the food sellers. Kṛṣṇadāsa explains that this was an established way for a niṣkiñcana devotee—someone with no independent support—to maintain life.

The change was not hidden from Mahāprabhu. Govinda reported that Raghunātha no longer took prasāda from him but stood at the Simha-dvāra and begged at night. Mahāprabhu was pleased.

That pleasure must be read together with the whole story. At Śāntipura, Mahāprabhu had forbidden the same man from displaying premature renunciation. Now, after obedience, Pāṇihāṭi, Nityānanda’s blessing, the final escape, and formal shelter under Svarūpa, Mahāprabhu approved when Raghunātha reduced dependence further. The difference was not simply that begging was holier than household life. The difference was ripeness.

Mahāprabhu then spoke generally about the life of a vairāgī. A renunciant, He said, should always perform nāma-saṅkīrtana and maintain the body by whatever alms come. A renunciant who remains dependent upon particular people will not reach the desired goal. One who renounces externally but remains driven by the tongue loses the deeper purpose and becomes controlled by taste.

The center of the teaching was not hunger. It was freedom for the name.

Again Mahāprabhu said: the duty of the vairāgī is sadā nāma-saṅkīrtana—always chanting the holy name. Food has a smaller role: enough leaves, vegetables, fruits or roots to keep the belly alive. The striking asymmetry is important. The body is maintained; nāma is the life.

But Raghunātha still had a question that begging could not answer. He had escaped his house. Why had he been delivered? What exactly was he supposed to do now?

He did not go directly to Mahāprabhu and speak freely. Kṛṣṇadāsa says that in the Lord’s presence Raghunātha hardly spoke at all. When he needed to express his heart, he did so through Svarūpa Dāmodara and Govinda. So he went to Svarūpa’s feet and asked about his duty: “I do not know the purpose for which I was made to leave home. What is my responsibility? Please instruct me.”

Svarūpa carried the question to Mahāprabhu.

Mahāprabhu smiled.

His first answer was almost to refuse the premise. “I have already given you Svarūpa as your instructor.” Learn sādhyā and sādhana from him, Mahāprabhu said—the truth of the goal and the truth of the means. Then He made an astonishingly humble statement about His own intimate companion: “I do not know as much as he knows.”

That sentence defines the educational structure of Raghunātha’s life in Purī. Mahāprabhu was not creating an independent ascetic whose spiritual life consisted only of private inspiration. He had deliberately placed Raghunātha under Svarūpa and expected him to learn there.

Still, Mahāprabhu continued: if you have faith in My instruction and want words directly from Me, then hold to these.

What followed occupies only a few lines.

Do not listen to grāmya-kathā. Do not speak grāmya-vārtā. The words are broader than a prohibition against one particular topic; they turn Raghunātha’s ears and speech away from the current of ordinary worldly conversation. Do not eat bhāla—fine, luxurious, highly pleasing food. Do not dress bhāla—finely. The heir of Saptagrāma was not to rebuild a refined version of the life he had left.

Then Mahāprabhu moved from restraint to positive practice: become amānī and mānada—do not seek honor for yourself, and give honor to others. Always take Kṛṣṇa’s name.

And then, in one line, Purī opened into Vraja.

vraje rādhā-kṛṣṇa-sevā mānase karibe—“In Vraja, serve Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa within the mind.”

The sentence is one of the great biographical keys to Raghunātha’s later life. His eventual residence at Govardhana and Rādhā-kuṇḍa did not begin only when his feet reached Vraja. Mahāprabhu had already placed Vraja inside his practice in Purī. Mental service to Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa was not a late invention of the old Gosvāmī at the kuṇḍa. It was part of the instruction he received while living under Svarūpa Dāmodara.

Mahāprabhu then quoted the verse that would become one of the defining summaries of His teaching: one should be humbler than grass, more tolerant than a tree, free from the demand for personal honor, ready to honor others—and in such a condition Hari can be chanted always.

Nāma, humility, simplicity, and mānasī-sevā were not four disconnected practices. They formed a single architecture. Ordinary talk was reduced so remembrance could deepen. Luxury was reduced so the senses would not occupy the center. The hunger for honor was reduced so nāma could continue. And within that purified attention, Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa were to be served in Vraja.

Mahāprabhu immediately refused to let those few sentences become a complete handbook detached from relationship. “This is the instruction I have given in brief,” He said. “You will receive its details from Svarūpa.”

Raghunātha heard the words, bowed at Mahāprabhu’s feet, and was embraced. Then Mahāprabhu again entrusted him to Svarūpa Dāmodara. Kṛṣṇadāsa says that from then on Raghunātha rendered antaraṅga-sevā with Svarūpa—confidential, inward service.

This is the proper beginning of “Svarūpera Raghu.” The name was not a sentimental nickname. It described a way of living. Mahāprabhu gave the essential direction; Svarūpa taught its intimate form. Raghunātha’s humility before the Lord, his silence, his renunciation, his absorption in nāma, and his mental life in Vraja all matured inside that relationship.

Much later, at Rādhā-kuṇḍa, Raghunātha would write prayers in which Svarūpa, Rūpa and Sanātana remained permanently present in his devotional genealogy. He would ask Govardhana for residence, call Rādhā-kuṇḍa his shelter, and pour out detailed prayers for intimate service to Rādhā. None of that requires us to imagine that Purī was left behind when Vraja began. The later Raghunātha grew from the instruction given here.

He had reached Caitanya’s feet. Now he had to become the person who could remain there.

## Renunciation Ripens

### *The wealth that followed him to Purī*

The instruction had been given. Raghunātha was to avoid ordinary worldly talk, live simply, take Kṛṣṇa's name constantly, honor others without seeking honor, and serve Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa in Vraja within the mind. But in Purī those words did not remain a compact set of teachings. They began to work themselves into the details of his life.

The first test came from Bengal.

When the Bengali devotees arrived in Jagannātha Purī, Raghunātha saw again the great public world of Mahāprabhu's associates: the cleansing of Guṇḍicā, the garden feast, Ratha-yātrā, Advaita Ācārya's affection, and the annual gathering of devotees. Śivānanda Sena also told him that his father had sent men after him when he fled, hoping to have him brought home. They had failed.

Four months later the Bengali pilgrims returned. Govardhana Majumadāra, still trying to understand what had become of his son, sent a messenger to Śivānanda. The report he received was striking. Raghunātha was not an unknown wanderer on the edge of Purī. He had become well known among Mahāprabhu's devotees. He lived under Svarūpa Dāmodara, remained near Caitanya, chanted constantly, cared almost nothing for clothing or food, and at night stood at the Siṁha-dvāra for whatever alms happened to come.

His parents heard this description not as a triumph but as distress. The household from which Raghunātha had escaped had possessed extraordinary wealth. Now their son sometimes ate, sometimes fasted, and sometimes maintained himself on a little fried grain. So Govardhana sent what a father of his world knew how to send: four hundred coins, two servants and a brāhmaṇa cook.

The wealth of Saptagrāma had followed Raghunātha all the way to Purī.

It did not immediately reclaim him. When the party eventually reached Jagannātha Purī with Śivānanda Sena, Raghunātha refused both the money and the men as his own support. Yet the severance was not absolute in a single moment. One servant and the brāhmaṇa remained with the funds, and Raghunātha began drawing from that money for a specific purpose: twice each month he invited Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu and arranged His meal.

That detail matters. Raghunātha did not first abandon family wealth because money itself had become ritually untouchable to him. For two years he could still redirect some of it toward service. His renunciation was becoming more exacting, but it was still being discerned in relationship.

Then he stopped the invitations.

Mahāprabhu noticed. After two months passed without them, He asked Svarūpa why Raghunātha no longer invited Him. The explanation Svarūpa gave was not that Raghunātha had grown tired of serving. It was that he had begun to examine the source of the arrangement and the subtle reward it gave him. The money came from the world he had renounced; by using it to host Mahāprabhu, he feared that the old network of dependence still entered his devotional life. And he saw another danger: reputation. A splendid invitation could become a way of being known as the person who fed the Lord.

Mahāprabhu smiled when He heard the reasoning. He did not command Raghunātha to resume the meals. Instead He affirmed the decision to stop.

The movement is easy to miss if Raghunātha's life is reduced to a collection of spectacular austerities. What was being stripped away was not merely food. It was leverage. Family wealth could still arrange circumstances. It could still place Raghunātha in the position of benefactor. It could still make service visible. By relinquishing it, he relinquished another way of controlling how he stood before Mahāprabhu.

Soon another refinement followed.

Raghunātha stopped standing at the Śiṁha-dvāra.

Mahāprabhu again noticed and asked Svarūpa what had changed. Svarūpa explained that Raghunātha had become dissatisfied with the inner life produced by waiting at the gate. Standing there, he could see particular people approach and begin calculating: perhaps this person will give; that person gave yesterday; another passed without giving; someone else may give next.

The problem was not that alms were too generous. The problem was expectation.

Mahāprabhu approved the change and used deliberately severe language for the psychology of selective waiting. A renunciant who watches particular donors and mentally depends on one person or another has lost neutrality. The external posture may still be begging, but the mind has begun making private contracts with the people walking past.

Raghunātha therefore began taking food from the public charity booth, the chatra. There he did not have to cultivate a particular giver. He went at midday, received whatever was distributed, filled the belly enough to continue, and left. Mahāprabhu praised precisely that impersonality: there was less occasion for expectation, bargaining, conversation or social dependence, and therefore more freedom to chant.

This was the renunciation Mahāprabhu had once refused to let Raghunātha imitate prematurely.

At Śāntipura, while still at home, Raghunātha had been told not to make a show of renunciation. He was to become steady within and behave appropriately without. Years later in Purī, every further reduction took place under the gaze of Mahāprabhu and Svarūpa. First he stopped receiving Govinda's daily plate. Then he stood at the Śiṁha-dvāra. Family money arrived and was refused as maintenance, then partially used in service, then abandoned even for that. Finally, the Śiṁha-dvāra itself was judged too entangled with expectation, and he moved to the anonymous charity booth.

Nothing here suggests haste. The movement is almost surgical.

Raghunātha was learning how little of the old world had to remain between the holy name and his attention.

And then, immediately after approving this new simplicity, Mahāprabhu placed Vraja into his hands.

## Govardhana in His Hands

### *The śilā, the guñjā-mālā, and Mahāprabhu's intention*

Raghunātha had just stopped waiting at the Siṁha-dvāra. He had given up calculating who might feed him and had moved to the anonymous charity booth, where he could accept whatever came and return to the holy name. At precisely this point in Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja's narrative, Mahāprabhu answered that increasing dispossession with a gift.

He gave Raghunātha Govardhana.

Not the hill in its visible expanse—not yet. Raghunātha was still in Jagannātha Purī. Mahāprabhu placed in his hands a stone from Govardhana and a guñjā-mālā. They were small enough to hold, but each already carried a history of intimacy with the Lord who gave them.

Kṛṣṇadāsa first turns backward. Śaṅkarānanda Sarasvatī had come from Vṛndāvana carrying the Govardhana-śilā and the guñjā garland and had presented them to Mahāprabhu. The Lord received the two objects with extraordinary joy. While chanting, He wore the guñjā-mālā around His neck. The stone He held against His heart and eyes. At times He smelled it; at times He placed it upon His head.

The śilā was continually wet with His tears.

Mahāprabhu did not treat it as a souvenir from Vraja. Kṛṣṇadāsa records His own words: kṛṣṇa-kalevara—“Kṛṣṇa's body.” For three years the Lord kept the stone and garland with Him. They became objects marked not only by the geography of Vraja but by Mahāprabhu's own touch, tears, fragrance, chanting and embrace.

Then He gave them away.

The text is explicit about why: Mahāprabhu was pleased with Raghunātha's conduct. The gifts therefore belong inside the biography of Raghunātha's maturation. They are not disconnected relics inserted into the story because he would later live at Govardhana. The Lord had watched the progression—his obedience, his dependence on Svarūpa, his refusal of family support, his relinquishing of social expectation—and then placed into his hands what He Himself had cherished for three years.

Mahāprabhu spoke first about the stone. “This śilā is Kṛṣṇa's vighraha,” He told Raghunātha. “Serve it with eagerness.” He instructed him to worship simply and purely, promising that such service would lead quickly to the wealth of kṛṣṇa-prema. The required paraphernalia were almost nothing: water and tulasī. Eight tender tulasī mañjarīs were to be offered with leaves arranged beside them.

For a man who had been progressively surrendering everything elaborate, the form of worship was perfectly fitted to his life. Yet simplicity did not mean smallness. Kṛṣṇadāsa says that the joy Raghunātha experienced from serving with water and tulasī exceeded what could be produced for him by a full sixteenfold ritual worship.

Svarūpa Dāmodara made the service possible in practical terms. He supplied small cloths, a wooden platform and a water vessel. Raghunātha began the worship in joy.

And during that worship the stone ceased to be merely something that reminded him of Kṛṣṇa. Kṛṣṇadāsa says that Raghunātha saw Vrajendra-nandana—the son of the king of Vraja, Nanda Mahārāja—within the śilā. The wording is biographically important. Mahāprabhu had called the stone Kṛṣṇa's very body; Raghunātha, serving it, beheld Nanda's son.

One fact intensified everything: prabhura svahasta-datta govardhana-śilā. This Govardhana stone had been given by the Lord’s own hand. Remembering that, Raghunātha became flooded with prema.

After he had worshiped in this simple way for some time, Svarūpa added another element. He told Raghunātha to offer fine khājā and sandeśa with faith and love. Govinda arranged the sweets. The movement is characteristic of Raghunātha’s life with Svarūpa: Mahāprabhu gave the essential command; Svarūpa taught him how to live its detail. The man called “Svarūpera Raghu” did not become spiritually independent when the śilā entered his hands.

But Kṛṣṇadāsa has still not revealed the entire meaning of the gift.

That meaning is placed in Raghunātha’s own mind.

When he received the śilā and guñjā-mālā, Raghunātha understood Mahāprabhu’s intention. The stone and garland together formed a map of his future:

“By giving the śilā, Gosāñi has offered me to Govardhana; by giving the guñjā-mālā, He has given me to Rādhikā’s feet.”

This is one of the most consequential sentences in his biography. We do not need a later interpreter to tell us that the śilā points toward Govardhana and the guñjā-mālā toward Rādhā. Kṛṣṇadāsa attributes that understanding directly to Raghunātha. Before Raghunātha ever left Purī for Vraja, Mahāprabhu had already placed the two poles of his later life into his hands: Govardhana and Rādhā-caraṇa.

The moment also illuminates an earlier instruction. Mahāprabhu had told Raghunātha: vraje rādhā-kṛṣṇa-sevā mānase karibe—serve Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa in Vraja within the mind. Now the geography of that inward service became tangible. Govardhana could be held. Rādhā’s shelter could be worn. The future Rādhā-kuṇḍa Gosvāmī was already being formed in Purī.

Raghunātha later remembered the event in his own Sanskrit. In Gaurāṅga-stava-kalpavṛkṣa 11 he compressed his life into a single chain of mercy: Gaurāṅga rescued him from the forest fire of immense wealth, placed him with His own Svarūpa, and gave him the beloved Govardhana-śilā and the guñjā garland from His chest. The verse is not merely a later biographer’s interpretation. It is Raghunātha’s own memory of what mattered.

The heir of Saptagrāma had once been surrounded by a fortune described in lakhs. In Purī he came to regard two objects as his inheritance: a stone wet with Caitanya’s tears and a garland that meant Rādhikā’s feet.

His external journey to Vraja was still years away. Govardhana had already arrived.

## Raghunātha's own remembrance

*mahā-sampad-dāvād api patitam uddhṛtya kṛpayā  
 svarūpe yaḥ svīye kujanam api mām nyasya muditaḥ |  
 uro-guñjā-hāraṁ priyam api ca govardhana-śilām  
 dadau me gaurāṅgo hṛdaya udayan mām madayati || 11 ||*

**Working translation:** Mercifully lifting me, fallen as I was, from the forest fire of immense wealth, Gaurāṅga joyfully placed even such a low person as me with His own Svarūpa. He gave me the guñjā garland from His chest and the beloved Govardhana-śilā. Rising within my heart, that Gaurāṅga maddens me.

**Source:** Raghunātha dāsa Gosvāmī, Gaurāṅga-stava-kalpavṛkṣa 11; quoted in Caitanya-caritāmṛta Antya 6.327.



## The Rice Even the Cows Refused

*When Mahāprabhu tasted Raghunātha's renunciation*

After the Govardhana-śilā and guñjā-mālā entered Raghunātha's life, Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja pauses. The story has already shown a young heir slipping out of a guarded house, a pilgrim reaching Purī after twelve days on the road, a disciple placed under Svarūpa Dāmodara, a renunciant moving from Govinda's plate to the Siṁha-dvāra and then to the public charity booth. Now Kṛṣṇadāsa asks, in effect, how such a life could even be described.

"Who can write the unlimited qualities of Raghunātha?" he says. His niyama—his fixed discipline—was like a line cut into stone.

The comparison is especially striking because Raghunātha had just received a stone from Govardhana. The text does not make that literary connection explicitly, but the sequence allows the reader to feel it: Mahāprabhu places Girirāja in his hands, and then Kṛṣṇadāsa describes the firmness of his life as something engraved in stone.

What followed was not inactivity. Kṛṣṇadāsa says that more than seven and a half praharas of the day and night—more than twenty-two hours—were spent in nāma and remembrance. Eating and sleep together occupied less than four daṇḍas, roughly an hour and a half, and on some days even that did not occur. His clothing was a small torn cloth and a patched wrapper. His food existed for one stated purpose: to keep body and soul together so that service could continue.

This is where the biography must resist an easy mistake. Raghunātha's renunciation was not presented as hatred of prasāda, hatred of the body, or a competition in suffering. Mahāprabhu had once forbidden him to imitate premature renunciation. In Purī, the same Mahāprabhu had first ordered Govinda to feed him after the exhausting journey. Every later reduction took place after years of formation, under Svarūpa's care and Mahāprabhu's direct observation.

Yet by this stage Raghunātha's concern for personal comfort had become almost unimaginably small.

Near the Siṁha-dvāra, sellers offered Lord Jagannātha's prasāda. Some cooked rice remained unsold. After two or three days it decomposed. Kṛṣṇadāsa says it was thrown before cows, but its odor had become so strong that even the cows would not eat it.

At night Raghunātha went there and gathered that rice.

He brought it home and washed it repeatedly in abundant water. The softened outer portion fell away. What remained was the hard inner core. He ate that with a little salt.

No donors had to notice him. No invitation had to be arranged. No food seller had to be approached. Even the charity booth was no longer necessary. The maintenance of the body had been reduced almost to anonymity.

Then Svarūpa Dāmodara discovered what he was doing.

Kṛṣṇadāsa does not make Svarūpa recoil. He makes him smile. Svarūpa asked for a little and ate it. Then, with the affectionate teasing that appears elsewhere in this relationship, he accused Raghunātha of keeping nectar to himself: "You eat such amṛta every day, but you do not give any to us. What kind of nature is this?"

That single word—amṛta, nectar—changes the scene. The rice remained materially rejected. Svarūpa did not deny its condition. But he refused to let Raghunātha's hidden life be interpreted

only through disgust. What Raghunātha considered scarcely worth mentioning became, in Svarūpa’s mouth, something precious because it was bound to his service and detachment.

Govinda carried the news to Mahāprabhu.

The next day the Lord came.

He did not wait for an invitation. “What wonderful thing are you eating? Why do you not give any to Me?” He said, and before Raghunātha could protect Him from it, Mahāprabhu took one morsel and ate.

When He reached for a second, Svarūpa caught His hand. “This is not fit for You,” he protested, and took it away.

Mahāprabhu answered with one of the most astonishing reversals in Raghunātha’s biography: day after day, He said, He ate many varieties of prasāda, but nowhere had He found a taste like this.

The Lord’s response is the climax of the episode. If the point were merely that spoiled rice is a superior diet, the story would collapse into absurdity. Kṛṣṇadāsa instead shows Mahāprabhu entering Raghunātha’s hidden austerity and revealing affection inside it. The rejected food becomes the occasion for intimacy between servant and Lord.

Raghunātha had spent years trying to disappear from the mechanisms of wealth, honor, dependence and taste. But he could not disappear from Mahāprabhu.

The Lord knew.

Svarūpa knew.

Govinda knew.

And when Mahāprabhu reached into Raghunātha’s vessel and ate from it, the austerity ceased to be merely private. It became part of Caitanya-līlā.

Kṛṣṇadāsa closes the sequence by saying that Mahāprabhu saw Raghunātha’s severe vairāgya and was greatly satisfied. Then, almost immediately, he quotes Raghunātha’s own Gaurāṅga-stava-kalpavṛkṣa, where Raghunātha remembers being rescued from the forest fire of immense wealth, placed with Svarūpa, and given the guñjā-mālā and Govardhana-śilā.

That is the true arc of Antya 6. Not wealth to starvation. Wealth to shelter. Govardhana Majumadāra’s son became Svarūpera Raghu; Svarūpera Raghu received Govardhana and Rādhā’s sign from Mahāprabhu; and even when he tried to live on what the world had thrown away, Mahāprabhu came looking for him.

The escape from Saptagrāma was over. The deeper story of Purī was only beginning.

***prabhu bale — “niti-niti nānā prasāda khāi  
aiche svāda āra kona prasāde nā pāi”***

“Day after day I eat many kinds of prasāda, but I do not find such a taste in any other prasāda.”  
— Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Antya 6.324

## Sixteen Years at the Heart of Antya-līlā

### *The memory Svarūpa placed in his voice*

The discarded-rice episode is unforgettable. It is also dangerous if it becomes the last image we keep of Raghunātha in Jagannātha Purī. His austerity was real, but austerity was not the center of his sixteen years there.

Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja says that Raghunātha rendered confidential service to Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu in Purī for sixteen years. The phrase is brief. Its implications are immense. The young man who had spent years trying to escape Bengal did not arrive in Purī merely to withdraw from society. He arrived to be placed inside a relationship.

Mahāprabhu had entrusted him to Svarūpa Dāmodara: “Accept him as your son or servant.” From that point the biography repeatedly returns to the same structure. Raghunātha did not become a solitary ascetic orbiting Caitanya from a distance. He became Svarūpera Raghu.

Raghunātha himself remembered his deliverance in almost exactly those terms. In Vilāpa-kusumāñjali 5 he looks back on household life as a nearly impossible dry well and praises Caitanya-candra for drawing him out by ropes of spontaneous mercy, bringing him to His lotus feet, and then placing him with Śrī Dāmodara.

That last movement matters. In Raghunātha’s own prayer, rescue from the house is not complete until he has been given to Svarūpa.

What did that gift become over sixteen years?

Kṛṣṇadāsa gives an answer in the place where the Caitanya-caritāmṛta enters some of its most difficult territory: Mahāprabhu’s final ecstatic life in separation from Kṛṣṇa. There he pauses the narrative and explains why he can speak at all. Svarūpa Dāmodara and Raghunātha dāsa, he says, lived with Mahāprabhu. The two of them recorded His activities in their kaḍacā—working notebooks or records. They noted His activities moment by moment, sometimes briefly and sometimes at greater length.

Then Kṛṣṇadāsa gives them distinct roles. Svarūpa was the sūtra-kartā, the maker of the concise thread or summary. Raghunātha was the vṛttikāra, the one who supplied fuller description.

The vocabulary is extraordinary because it restores a part of Raghunātha’s identity that disappears when his life is told only through fasting. He was not only a man who ate almost nothing. He was a man who watched, heard, remembered, and described.

This does not mean that every surviving sentence of Caitanya-caritāmṛta can be assigned mechanically to a lost page in Raghunātha’s hand. Kṛṣṇadāsa is not giving us a modern archival catalog. He is giving us something more important for biography: his own explicit account of the transmission by which the most intimate Caitanya-līlā reached him.

Elsewhere he states it with crystalline clarity. The jewel-essence of Caitanya’s pastimes, he says, was Svarūpa’s treasury. Svarūpa placed that treasure in Raghunātha’s kaṇṭha—his throat, voice, living recitation—and Kṛṣṇadāsa heard from there. What little he heard, he says, he expanded in his book and offered to the devotees.

The line makes Raghunātha into a bridge between two worlds. On one side stands Purī: Mahāprabhu, Svarūpa, the Gambhīrā, the final years of ecstatic separation, and the circle that

directly witnessed them. On the other side stands Vraja: Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja, the Gosvāmī community, Rādhā-kuṇḍa, and the book through which later generations would enter those years. Raghunātha stands between them carrying memory.

Kṛṣṇadāsa repeats the claim at the close of his account of Haridāsa Ṭhākura. Whatever Svarūpa Gosvāmī wrote in his notes about Caitanya’s līlā, he says, he heard from the mouth of Raghunātha dāsa. This is not a later tradition trying to enhance Raghunātha’s prestige. It is the author of Caitanya-caritāmṛta naming one of his sources.

The relationship becomes even more personal in Kṛṣṇadāsa’s own autobiography. He says that by mercy he attained the great Raghunātha, and through Raghunātha he attained the shelter of Śrī Svarūpa. The chain runs backward as well as forward: Kṛṣṇadāsa reaches Svarūpa through Raghunātha; Caitanya-līlā reaches Kṛṣṇadāsa through Raghunātha from Svarūpa.

This helps explain why Raghunātha’s later life at Rādhā-kuṇḍa cannot be separated from Purī. When the elderly Gosvāmī spoke for hours about Caitanya, he was not repeating stories gathered secondhand in Vraja. He had spent sixteen years inside the world he described.

Nor should those sixteen years be imagined as an unbroken literary workshop. The sources portray a devotional life, not an office. Raghunātha served, chanted, begged, worshiped the Govardhana-śilā, received instruction, watched Mahāprabhu’s moods deepen, and remained under Svarūpa’s care. The notebooks arise from that life; they are not a substitute for it.

The word “confidential” therefore deserves weight. Mahāprabhu’s gift to Raghunātha was not simply proximity to a famous saint. It was admission, through Svarūpa, into a circle where the Lord’s interior devotional life could be witnessed and served without spectacle.

That also changes the meaning of the Govardhana-śilā in the previous chapter. Mahāprabhu did not place Govardhana into the hands of an outsider. He gave it to someone who had been formed beside Him, under Svarūpa, and whose memory was already becoming a vessel for Caitanya-līlā.

And it changes the meaning of the years to come. When Raghunātha eventually reaches Vraja, Rūpa and Sanātana will not merely rescue an exhausted ascetic. Kṛṣṇadāsa says they will repeatedly hear from him about Mahāprabhu’s external and internal pastimes because he had served as Svarūpa’s assistant and knew them deeply.

The road from Purī to Rādhā-kuṇḍa therefore carries more than a person. It carries testimony.

For sixteen years Raghunātha had lived near the source of that testimony. Then the two persons around whom his Purī life had been built—Mahāprabhu and Svarūpa Dāmodara—were gone.

That is where the next chapter begins.

### Raghunātha’s own remembrance

*yo mām dustara-geha-nirjala-mahā-kūpād apāra-klamāt  
sadyaḥ sāndra-dayāmbudhiḥ prakṛtiḥ svairī-kṛpā-rajjubhiḥ |  
uddhṛtyātma-saroja-nindi-carāṇa-prāntaṁ prapādyā svayaṁ  
śrī-dāmodara-sāc-cakāra tam ahaṁ caitanya-candraṁ bhaje ||5||*

Working translation: I worship Caitanya-candra, the dense ocean of mercy, who drew me from the nearly impassable, waterless well of household life by the ropes of His spontaneous grace, brought me to the edge of His lotus feet, and personally placed me with Śrī Dāmodara.

*Rāghunātha dāsa Gosvāmī, Vilāpa-kusumāñjali 5*

## When the Two Lights Disappeared

*From Purī to the feet of Rūpa and Sanātana*

For sixteen years, Jagannātha Purī had been the place Raghunātha had spent his youth trying to reach. He had crossed Bengal to get there, placed his life at Mahāprabhu's feet, and been given into the hands of Svarūpa Dāmodara. Purī was not merely where he lived. It was the world in which his renounced life had acquired meaning.

Then that world ended.

Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja records the transition with extraordinary restraint. Raghunātha, he says, rendered confidential service for sixteen years. After the disappearance of Mahāprabhu and Svarūpa Dāmodara, he went to Vṛndāvana.

The sentence is almost painfully brief. It does not tell us the exact physical circumstances of Mahāprabhu's disappearance. It does not narrate a final scene between the Lord and Raghunātha. Nor does it tell us how long Raghunātha remained in Purī between the loss of Mahāprabhu and the loss of Svarūpa. Later devotional traditions fill the silence with grief-filled remembrance, but the first-generation biographical spine is simpler and firmer: both persons around whom Raghunātha's Purī life had been formed were gone, and Raghunātha left.

The force of that sentence becomes clearer only when the preceding chapters are remembered.

Mahāprabhu had not merely inspired Raghunātha. He had received the runaway heir of Saptagrāma, arranged that his exhausted body be fed, instructed him in humility, nāma and mental service to Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa in Vraja, tasted the food of his renunciation, and placed Govardhana and the guñjā-mālā into his hands.

Svarūpa Dāmodara had not merely been another respected devotee nearby. Mahāprabhu had formally entrusted Raghunātha to him as son or servant. Raghunātha learned the detailed form of the Lord's instruction from him, served beside him, and helped preserve the memory of Mahāprabhu's final līlā with him.

To lose Mahāprabhu was therefore to lose the Lord whose feet he had spent his earlier life trying to attain. To lose Svarūpa was to lose the person into whose hands that same Lord had placed him.

Purī remained holy. Jagannātha remained. The sea, the Siṁha-dvāra, the Gambhīrā and the roads of Nīlācala remained. But the two relationships that had made Raghunātha's life there intelligible were no longer available in the same visible form.

Kṛṣṇadāsa tells us what Raghunātha decided to do next.

He would go to Vṛndāvana. First he would see the feet of Rūpa and Sanātana. Then he intended to give up his life at Govardhana.

The wording must be allowed to remain as severe as the text makes it. This was not a planned new stage of pilgrimage, nor a serene retirement from Purī. Raghunātha set out carrying an intention born from unbearable separation. The same Govardhana that Mahāprabhu had earlier placed symbolically into his hands had now become, in his grief, the place where he expected his embodied life to end.

That intention should not be detached from its narrative outcome or turned into a devotional ideal to imitate. Kṛṣṇadāsa tells the story precisely because it does not end there. Rūpa and Sanātana will

refuse to let him die. The grief is real; the intended death is real within the narrative; and the answer to it will be relationship.

Before that answer, however, Raghunātha had to reach them.

The Caitanya-caritāmṛta gives no itinerary for his journey from Purī to Vraja. It names no sequence of overnight stops and no reconstructed road. The biography should not invent one. Kṛṣṇadāsa simply says that Raghunātha came to Vṛndāvana having fixed this determination within himself.

There he saw Rūpa and Sanātana.

The scene is again told with almost no ornament. Raghunātha approached the two brothers and bowed at their feet.

Those feet mattered before this meeting. Mahāprabhu’s own instruction had already placed Raghunātha inside a Vraja-oriented life, and Raghunātha’s later prayers would repeatedly name Svarūpa, Rūpa and Sanātana together as the relationships through which his devotional identity had been formed. But now the meeting was no longer theological architecture or distant reverence. He had come to them bereaved, intending that this darśana would be the last human shelter he accepted before Govardhana.

He bowed.

And the two brothers did not let the story end as he had planned.

### The first-generation narrative spine

#### Caitanya-caritāmṛta, Ādi 10.93–95

ṣoḍaśa vatsara kaila antaraṅga-sevana / svarūpera antardhāne āila vṛndāvana || 93 ||

vṛndāvane dui bhāira caraṇa dekhiyā / govardhane tyajiba deha bhṛgupāta kariyā || 94 ||

ei ta’ niścaya kari’ āila vṛndāvane / āsi’ rūpa-sanātanera vandila caraṇe || 95 ||

Working translation: For sixteen years he rendered confidential service. After Svarūpa’s disappearance, he came to Vṛndāvana. (The received biographical translation understands Mahāprabhu’s disappearance as already preceding this.) He thought: “After seeing the feet of the two brothers in Vṛndāvana, I shall give up this body at Govardhana by falling from a height.” Having fixed this determination, he came to Vṛndāvana and bowed at the feet of Rūpa and Sanātana.



## Rūpa and Sanātana Refuse His Death

*The third brother and the memory he carried from Purī*

Raghunātha had not come to Vṛndāvana in search of a new beginning.

He had come to say farewell.

His intention, as Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja states it with unusual starkness, was to see the feet of Rūpa and Sanātana and then go to Govardhana and give up his body by falling from the hill. Purī had held the two relationships around which his mature life had been formed: Mahāprabhu and Svarūpa Dāmodara. With both gone from his sight, Raghunātha no longer imagined a future for himself.

But the journey did not end according to the plan with which he began it.

He reached Vṛndāvana, came before Rūpa and Sanātana, and bowed to them. Kṛṣṇadāsa gives no elaborate dramatic dialogue. The next line is enough.

*tabe dui bhāi tāñre marite nā dila  
nija tṛtīya bhāi kari' nikaṭe rākhila*

*“Then the two brothers did not allow him to die. They accepted him as their own third brother and kept him near them.”*

That sentence changes the direction of the biography.

Rūpa and Sanātana did not merely persuade an ascetic to abandon a dangerous impulse. The language is familial: *nija tṛtīya bhāi* — their own third brother. Raghunātha arrived as a man who believed his work was finished. They answered by giving him a place inside their own relationship.

The phrase also reveals something essential about Gauḍīya renunciation. Raghunātha’s life did not become holier by becoming increasingly solitary. At every decisive stage, another Vaiṣṇava relationship interrupted the possibility of spiritual independence. Haridāsa had blessed the boy. Mahāprabhu had restrained his premature renunciation. Nityānanda had opened the door through service. Mahāprabhu had placed him with Svarūpa. Now, when grief had turned toward death, Rūpa and Sanātana kept him alive.

And they did not keep him merely so that he might survive.

They listened to him.

*mahāprabhura līlā yata bāhira-antara  
dui bhāi tāñra mukhe śune nirantara*

*“Whatever external and internal līlās of Mahāprabhu there were, the two brothers continuously heard from his mouth.”*

The man who had come to Govardhana to silence his own life became a voice.

That reversal is one of the most beautiful movements in Raghunātha’s story. In Purī he had lived under Svarūpa Dāmodara and had learned to hear Mahāprabhu from within the Lord’s intimate circle. Kṛṣṇadāsa later describes Svarūpa as the maker of concise notes and Raghunātha as the one who elaborated them. Now that living memory entered Vraja through Raghunātha’s speech.

Rūpa and Sanātana already possessed their own direct histories with Mahāprabhu. Rūpa had been instructed at Prayāga; Sanātana at Kāśī. Both had been sent to Vraja and entrusted with enormous



theological and practical work. Yet Kṛṣṇadāsa still depicts them listening nirantara — continually — to Raghunātha’s account of Mahāprabhu’s bāhira and antara līlās.

The words bāhira and antara should not be reduced too quickly to “public” and “secret.” They indicate an outer and inner range in Mahāprabhu’s life: events visible in the world, and the deeper currents of His interior devotional states. Raghunātha had stood close enough to Svarūpa to receive both.

So Raghunātha’s arrival in Vraja brought more than another Gosvāmī into the community. It brought a living Purī archive.

His own writings show that this rescue by Rūpa and Sanātana did not disappear from his devotional self-understanding. In Manaḥ-śikṣā, when he instructs his own mind how to obtain residence in Vraja and service to the Divine Couple, he does not recommend an isolated mystical path. He tells the mind to remember and bow in love to Svarūpa, Śrī Rūpa, Rūpa’s associates, and Rūpa’s elder brother — Sanātana.

*yadīccher āvāsaṁ vraja-bhuvi sa-rāgaṁ pratījanur  
yuva-dvandvaṁ tac cet paricaritum ārād abhilaṣeḥ |  
svarūpaṁ śrī-rūpaṁ sa-gaṇam iha tasyāgrajam api  
sphuṭaṁ premṇā nityaṁ smara nama tadā tvaṁ śṛṇu manaḥ ||3||*

*“O mind, if in birth after birth you desire loving residence in the land of Vraja, and if you long directly to serve the youthful Divine Couple, then always remember and bow with manifest love to Svarūpa, Śrī Rūpa with his associates, and his elder brother as well.”*

The sequence is autobiographical even though the poem is an instruction to the mind. Purī and Vraja are not separated by forgetting. Svarūpa remains beside Rūpa and Sanātana inside the very discipline by which Raghunātha teaches himself to live in Vraja.

His prayer to Sanātana is even more personal. Near the opening of Vilāpa-kusumāñjali, immediately after remembering Caitanya-candra placing him with Dāmodara, Raghunātha turns to Sanātana:

*vairāgya-yug-bhakti-rasa-prayatnair  
apāyayan mām anabhīpsam andham |  
kṛpāmbudhir yaḥ para-duḥkha-duḥkhī  
sanātanaṁ taṁ prabhum āśrayāmi ||6||*

*“I take shelter of that master Sanātana, an ocean of mercy who suffers at the suffering of others, and who, by his efforts in the nectar of devotion joined with renunciation, made even me — blind and unwilling — drink.”*

The language is revealing. Sanātana is not remembered only as a revered elder whose feet Raghunātha once saw before going to Govardhana. He is remembered as the compassionate person who actively made him drink bhakti-rasa joined with vairāgya.

That is what Rūpa and Sanātana’s refusal of his death became: not a temporary intervention, but a new apprenticeship in Vraja.

Raghunātha had escaped wealth. He had escaped guards. He had survived the road to Purī. He had learned from Mahāprabhu, lived under Svarūpa, stripped his maintenance down to almost nothing, and then survived the loss of the two persons who had become the center of his life.

At Govardhana, however, he encountered a form of mercy he could not renounce.

The two brothers kept him.

And because they kept him, the memory of Mahāprabhu that Svarūpa had placed in his voice did not end in grief. It was spoken in Vraja, heard by Rūpa and Sanātana, and eventually transmitted onward into the literature by which later generations would know Caitanya's final years.

Only after this rescue can the biography properly move to Rādhā-kuṇḍa.

Raghunātha did not arrive there as a solitary ascetic who had cut himself free from every bond. He arrived carrying Mahāprabhu's command, Svarūpa's formation, the Govardhana-śilā and guñjā-mālā, and the life Rūpa and Sanātana had refused to let him throw away.

## Rādhā-kuṇḍa Becomes His Abode

*“Here alone shall be my residence”*

Rūpa and Sanātana had refused to let Raghunātha die at Govardhana. The question that remained was what kind of life could follow such a rescue.

The answer was not a return to the world he had left, nor even a permanent place beside the two brothers in Vṛndāvana. His life moved toward the landscape Mahāprabhu had already placed into his hands years before in Purī.

Govardhana.

Rādhā-kuṇḍa.

The movement should be read first through Raghunātha’s own prayers, because those prayers reveal what residence meant to him. They are not municipal records and they do not supply a civil date for when he first settled at the kuṇḍa. But they tell us with extraordinary clarity what place had become the geography of his heart.

**Govardhana: “Grant me residence near you”**

In the opening verse of his Govardhana-vāsa-prārthanā-daśaka, Raghunātha addresses Girirāja directly. He remembers Govardhana becoming the umbrella raised on Kṛṣṇa’s arm and breaking Indra’s pride. Then the prayer becomes personal:

*nija-pati-bhuja-daṇḍā-chatra-bhāvaṁ prapadya  
pratihata-mada-dhr̥ṣṭoddāṇḍa-devendra-garva |  
atula-pr̥thula-śaila-śreṇi-bhūpa priyaṁ me  
nija-nikaṭa-nivāsaṁ dehi govardhana tvam || 1 ||*

*“O Govardhana, incomparable king of great mountains, who became the umbrella upon your Lord’s arm and shattered the proud audacity of Indra: please grant me the residence I cherish near you.”*

The prayer makes visible what Mahāprabhu’s gift of the Govardhana-śilā had already suggested. In Purī, Raghunātha had understood the stone as the Lord giving him Govardhana. In Vraja, the desire becomes a direct petition for nikaṭa-nivāsa — residence nearby.

Yet even Govardhana is not the final narrowing of the map.

**Rādhā-kuṇḍa alone is my shelter**

Raghunātha’s Rādhā-kuṇḍāṣṭaka repeats the same refrain at the end of every verse:

*tad ati-surabhi rādhā-kuṇḍam evāśrayo me*

*“May that exceedingly fragrant Rādhā-kuṇḍa alone be my shelter.”*

The repeated evāśrayo me — “alone is my shelter” — does more than praise a celebrated tīrtha. Across the eight verses Raghunātha describes why this one place has become his refuge.

Here the lake manifested from Śrī Rādhā’s own hand together with Her sakhīs. Here service to the kuṇḍa causes the vine of divine love to arise and flower as service to his Mistress. Around its banks

stand the intimate kuñjas associated with Her own companions. On those banks Rādhā speaks sweetly with Her prāṇa-sakhīs. And day after day Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa sport in its waters surrounded by the intoxicated circle of loving friends.

For Raghunātha, therefore, Rādhā-kuṇḍa is not merely sacred water. It is a complete environment of service.

*api jana iha kaścīd yasya sevā-prasādaiḥ  
praṇaya-sura-latā syāt tasya goṣṭhendra-sūnoḥ |  
sapadi kila mad-īśā-dāsyā-puṣpa-praśasyā  
tad ati-surabhi rādhā-kuṇḍam evāśrayo me ||5||*

*“By the grace of serving this kuṇḍa, the celestial vine of love for the son of the lord of Vraja may arise in someone’s heart and immediately become glorious with the flower of service to my Mistress. May that exceedingly fragrant Rādhā-kuṇḍa alone be my shelter.”*

The phrase mad-īśā-dāsyā — “service to my Mistress” — is one of the keys to the whole late biography. His residence is not primarily an experiment in geographical austerity. It is ordered toward Rādhā-dāsyā.

The final verse of the aṣṭaka makes the landscape fully alive:

*anudinam ati-raṅgaiḥ prema-mattāli-saṅghair  
vara-sarasija-gandhair hāri-vāri-prapūrṇe |  
viharata iha yasmin dam-patī tau pramattau  
tad ati-surabhi rādhā-kuṇḍam evāśrayo me ||8||*

*“Day after day, in waters filled with the fragrance of splendid lotuses and surrounded by groups of companions maddened with love, the Divine Couple sport here in overflowing delight. May that exceedingly fragrant Rādhā-kuṇḍa alone be my shelter.”*

**“Here alone shall be my residence”**

If the Rādhā-kuṇḍāṣṭaka repeatedly names the kuṇḍa as shelter, Vilāpa-kusumāñjali makes the residence-prayer almost impossible to soften into metaphor.

Near the culmination of that work, Raghunātha addresses Śrī Rādhā:

*sva-kuṇḍam tava lolākṣi  
sa-priyāyāḥ sadāspadam |  
atraiva mama saṁvāsa  
ihaiva mama saṁsthiṭiḥ ||97||*

*“O restless-eyed one, Your own kuṇḍa is the eternal abode of You together with Your beloved. Here alone shall be my residence; here alone shall be my abiding place.”*

atraiva — here alone. ihaiva — here alone.

The double insistence is the clearest self-authored statement of Raghunātha’s geographical commitment. Rādhā-kuṇḍa is where he asks to live and where he asks to remain.

This does not by itself give the historian a settlement date. Prayer is not a deed. But it prevents a biography from treating Rādhā-kuṇḍa as an accidental retirement site. Whatever the exact chronology of his first residence, the place became his chosen devotional home.

### A day almost entirely given away

Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja then gives the mature portrait.

The numbers are so extreme that later biographies sometimes sound legendary when they repeat them. In this case, however, the core numerical portrait is already in Caitanya-caritāmṛta.

Raghunātha gradually reduced food and drink until he took only a very small quantity of buttermilk. Each day he offered a thousand daṇḍavats, chanted at least one lakh of holy names, and offered respect to two thousand Vaiṣṇavas.

But the center of the schedule is not arithmetic. It is the continuity between Purī and Rādhā-kuṇḍa.

*rātri-dine rādhā-kṛṣṇera mānasa sevana  
prahareka mahāprabhura caritra-kathana*

*“Day and night he served Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa within the mind, and for one prahara he spoke of the character and līlā of Mahāprabhu.”*

The instruction Mahāprabhu had given him in Purī — vraje rādhā-kṛṣṇa-sevā mānase karibe, “serve Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa in Vraja within the mind” — had become the architecture of his day. Yet Mahāprabhu had not been displaced by Vraja. Raghunātha still spent roughly three hours every day speaking Caitanya-caritra.

Purī had become memory; Vraja had become place; neither was abandoned.

Then Kṛṣṇadāsa names Rādhā-kuṇḍa itself:

*tina sandhyā rādhā-kuṇḍe apatita snāna  
vraja-vāsī vaiṣṇave kare āliṅgana māna*

*“At the three junctions of the day he bathed without fail in Rādhā-kuṇḍa, and he embraced and honored the Vaiṣṇavas who lived in Vraja.”*

The portrait is easy to distort if only the austerity is remembered. The verse places repeated bathing at the kuṇḍa beside the embrace and honoring of Vrajavāsī Vaiṣṇavas. Raghunātha’s life at Rādhā-kuṇḍa was not simply private absorption beside water.

Kṛṣṇadāsa closes with the famous time summary: more than seven and a half praharas — over twenty-two and a half hours — were given to devotional practice. Less than two hours remained for sleep, and on some days even that did not occur.

Then Kṛṣṇadāsa stops counting.

*tānhāra sādhanā-rīti śunite camatkāra  
sei rūpa-raghunātha prabhu ye āmāra*

*“I am filled with wonder to hear of his way of sādhanā. That Rūpa and Raghunātha are my masters.”*

This is one of the reasons Raghunātha's life at the kuṇḍa matters beyond personal ascetic biography. The man who had once carried Svarūpa's memory into Vraja now became one of Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja's own guiding authorities.

At Rādhā-kuṇḍa, the strands of the whole life meet.

Mahāprabhu's instruction becomes mānasī-sevā. The Govardhana-śilā becomes residence near Girirāja. The guñjā-mālā's shelter at Rādhā's feet becomes Rādhā-dāsyā. Svarūpa's Caitanya-līlā remains on his tongue. Rūpa and Sanātana remain inside his prayer. And the lake Mahāprabhu had recognized in obscurity becomes the place from which Raghunātha asks never to depart.

Here alone shall be my residence.

The next stage of his biography is therefore not simply “what Raghunātha did at Rādhā-kuṇḍa.” It is what Rādhā-kuṇḍa became around him: the restoration of the two waters, the acceptance of a kuṭīra at Sanātana's insistence, the gathering of a Gauḍīya community, and the arrival of the next generation of pilgrims.

## The Sevaka of Rādhā-kuṇḍa

*Care for the waters, the kuṭīra, and a sacred community*

Raghunātha had prayed to remain at Rādhā-kuṇḍa. Residence, however, eventually required another kind of service.

The waters themselves needed care.

The full history of that transformation belongs elsewhere in this project. For Raghunātha's biography, one feature matters most: even when his desire was entirely directed toward the service of Rādhā-kuṇḍa, his fear of becoming entangled in wealth did not disappear.

Bhakti-ratnākara remembers him suddenly thinking how good it would be if the two kuṇḍas were full and properly restored. Then the practical consequence struck him. Such work required money.

*Raghunātha suddenly desired that the two kuṇḍas be filled with water. But when the thought of money entered the matter, he became almost stunned, repeatedly reproaching himself: “Why has such a desire arisen in my mind?”*

The scene is characteristic. He did not abandon the service because it involved material means, but neither did he immediately begin fundraising. The man who had spent his Purī years cutting away dependence on wealth now found himself wanting to serve a sacred place in a way that could not be accomplished by personal austerity alone.

In Narahari Cakravartī's account, the resolution comes without Raghunātha seeking a patron.

An unnamed wealthy pilgrim — the text simply says “a certain rich man” — went to Badarikāśrama and offered money there. In a dream he was directed to take those funds to Āriṣṭa and place them in Raghunātha's hands for the service of the two kuṇḍas.

When the pilgrim arrived and explained the command, Raghunātha accepted the service. He ordered paṅkoddhāra — the removal of mud and silt — and many laborers were engaged. Bhakti-ratnākara then says the two kuṇḍas were carefully caused to be dug.

*“Quickly undertake the removal of the mud of the two kuṇḍas.” Hearing this, the patron was filled with joy; many people were engaged at once, and the two kuṇḍas were carefully excavated.*

That is enough for the biography. Raghunātha did not create Rādhā-kuṇḍa and Śyāma-kuṇḍa. The sacred manifestation belongs to a much earlier layer of the tradition. What Bhakti-ratnākara remembers here is substantial restoration under his direction.

The same account preserves a famous explanation for the irregular form of Śyāma-kuṇḍa: trees standing in the path of the work were to be cut, but Raghunātha dreamed that Yudhiṣṭhira told him the five Pāṇḍavas were present there in tree form. Raghunātha therefore protected them, and the lake was not made square.

For the Rādhā-kuṇḍa Story, that tradition deserves its full geographical setting. Here its biographical importance is simpler. When service to the kuṇḍa encountered something Raghunātha regarded as sacred, efficiency yielded to reverence.

The waters were enlarged and cleared. Raghunātha remained Raghunātha.

### Sanātana makes him accept a roof

Bhakti-ratnākara immediately follows the restoration account with another scene, and the sequence is revealing.

Raghunātha still had no desire for a dwelling.

*“Day and night Raghunātha remained beneath a tree; he never had any desire to make a kuṭīra.”*

One day Sanātana Gosvāmī came from Vṛndāvana and went toward Mānasa-pāvana to bathe. Narahari says that he saw a tiger come to the water to drink and then pass back toward the forest, crossing close to the place where Raghunātha sat absorbed in meditation.

Raghunātha apparently noticed none of it.

When his meditation ended, he saw Sanātana, approached him and offered obeisance. Sanātana did not praise his fearlessness. Out of affection, he told him to stop living beneath the tree and stay in a kuṭīra.

*Out of affection for Raghunātha, Sanātana spoke gently: “Now leave the base of the tree and live in a kuṭīra.” The construction of the kuṭīra began that very day.*

The episode is small, but it belongs beside Mahāprabhu’s first days of feeding Raghunātha in Purī. Again, the care of the body does not come from Raghunātha’s own concern for comfort. It comes through relationship.

And again, obedience is more important than performing an image of extreme renunciation.

The kuṭīra therefore should not be read as a weakening of his vairāgya. In the early Vraja memory, accepting shelter is itself an act of submission to Sanātana.

Nor should the present memorial structure automatically be identified with the exact sixteenth-century hut. The tradition securely remembers a kuṭīra associated with this episode; the architectural continuity of the modern site is a separate historical question.

### A hermitage that did not remain solitary

By this point, Rādhā-kuṇḍa was no longer simply the place where Raghunātha withdrew from the world.

It was becoming a place to which others came.

Later in Bhakti-ratnākara, Śrīnivāsa and Narottama are brought to the aged Raghunātha. Though physically weak, he rises to embrace them. Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja and other Vaiṣṇavas of Rādhā-kuṇḍa appear in the same social landscape. Rāmacandra Kavirāja likewise comes to Āriṭa, bathes, bows to Raghunātha and is received with affection.

The important point for this biography is not to catalogue every visitor. It is to see what Raghunātha’s residence had become.

He had come to Vraja intending to die.

Rūpa and Sanātana kept him alive.



At Rādhā-kuṇḍa he prayed for permanent residence, directed service to the waters without pursuing wealth for himself, accepted a kuṭīra only when Sanātana told him to, and gradually became one of the elders around whom the next generation of Gauḍīya Vaiṣṇavas gathered.

The ascetic beneath the tree became, without ceasing to be an ascetic, a caretaker of place and a center of relationship.

That is the biographical meaning of his service to Rādhā-kuṇḍa.

## The Poet of Longing

*What Raghunātha's own writings reveal*

If Raghunātha dāsa is remembered only for torn cloth, little food, thousands of obeisances and almost no sleep, then half of the man disappears.

His writings restore the missing half.

The same person who reduced his bodily needs almost to nothing wrote with extraordinary density about relationship, place, memory, longing, humor, beauty and service. His vairāgya was severe, but his literary world was not empty. It was crowded with persons he loved: Caitanya-candra, Svarūpa Dāmodara, Rūpa, Sanātana, Govardhana, Rādhā-kuṇḍa, the sakhīs and mañjarīs, and above all Śrī Rādhā.

For biography, these poems matter because they let Raghunātha speak in the first person.

### Gaurāṅga remembered as the one who gave him everything

In Gaurāṅga-stava-kalpavṛkṣa, Raghunātha does not remember Mahāprabhu abstractly. He remembers what the Lord did to him.

One verse gathers almost the whole earlier biography into four lines:

*mahā-sampad-dāvād api patitam uddhṛtya kṛpayā  
svarūpe yaḥ svīye kujanam api mām nyasya muditaḥ |  
uro-guñjā-hāraṁ priyam api ca govardhana-śilām  
dadau me gaurāṅgo hṛdaya udayan mām madayati || 11 ||*

*“By mercy He lifted even me, fallen into the forest fire of immense wealth; joyfully He placed this unworthy person with His own Svarūpa, and He gave me the dear guñjā garland from His chest and the beloved Govardhana-śilā. May that Gaurāṅga rise within my heart and intoxicate me.”*

The verse is devotional poetry, but it is also autobiographical memory. Wealth is remembered as danger; Svarūpa as the person into whose care Mahāprabhu personally placed him; and the guñjā-mālā and Govardhana-śilā as gifts whose meaning continued into his Vraja life.

The mature Raghunātha therefore did not outgrow Caitanya. His Rādhā-kuṇḍa life remained explicitly Gaurāṅga-given.

### Manah-śikṣā: the ascetic instructs his own mind

Manah-śikṣā is often read as a compact manual of inner practice. Biographically, its striking feature is the speaker's tone. Raghunātha does not address an audience from above. He begs and disciplines his own mind.

*gurau goṣṭhe goṣṭhālayiṣu sujane bhū-sura-gaṇe  
sva-mantre śrī-nāmnī vraja-nava-yuva-dvandva-smaraṇe |  
sadā dambhaṁ hitvā kuru ratim apūrvām atitarāṁ  
aye svāntar bhrātaś caṭubhir abhiyāce dhṛta-padaḥ || 1 ||*

*“O my brother mind, grasping your feet I flatter and implore you: abandon pride and develop extraordinary, ever-deepening love for guru, Vraja, the residents and servants of Vraja, the brāhmaṇas, your mantra, the holy name, and remembrance of the youthful Divine Couple.”*

The first enemy named is dambha — pride, pretension, self-display. That matters in the life of a man whose austerities later became famous. His own instruction does not say, “Become known for renunciation.” It says: abandon pride and cultivate attachment to persons, places and practices of devotion.

The same work later tells his mind that if it desires residence in Vraja and direct service to the youthful Couple, it must constantly remember Svarūpa, Śrī Rūpa, Rūpa’s associates and his elder brother Sanātana. The inward path remains relational.

This is one of the clearest ways to understand Raghunātha’s vairāgya. Renunciation clears space. It is not the final content of the space.

### Vilāpa-kusumāñjali: the servant who cannot live without her Mistress

No work reveals Raghunātha’s inner devotional voice more powerfully than Vilāpa-kusumāñjali.

It opens not with Raghunātha presenting himself as a great renunciant, scholar or elder, but by addressing Rūpa Mañjarī. The poem then unfolds in the voice of a dāsī burning in separation from her Mistress.

*atyutkaṭena nitarāṁ virahānalena  
dandahyamāna-hṛdayā kila kāpi dāsī |  
hā svāmini kṣaṇam iha praṇayena gāḍham  
ākrandanena vidhurā vilapāmi padyaiḥ || 7 ||*

*“A certain maidservant, her heart intensely scorched by the blazing fire of separation, cries out: ‘O my Mistress!’ Overwhelmed, I lament here in verses, calling to You with deep love.”*

That self-positioning is essential. Raghunātha’s late theology is not merely that Rādhā is exalted. It is that he seeks identity through service to Her.

The longing becomes almost unbearable near the end of the work:

*āśā-bharair amṛta-sindhu-mayaiḥ kathañcit  
kālo mayātigamitaḥ kila sāmprataṁ hi |  
tvaṁ cet kṛpāṁ mayi vidhāsyasi naiva kiṁ me  
prāṇair vrajena ca varoru bakāriṇāpi || 102 ||*

*“Until now I have somehow passed the time sustained by hopes filled with an ocean of nectar. But if You will not bestow Your mercy upon me, O beautiful-thighed one, then what use to me are life itself, Vraja, or even Kṛṣṇa?”*

Read in isolation, such language can sound like negation. Inside the poem, however, its center is positive and specific: the desired mercy is service to Rādhā. Even Vraja and Kṛṣṇa are valued through that axis of service.

This is the literary heart behind the biographical phrase Rādhā-dāsyā.

### Govardhana and Rādhā-kuṇḍa: longing becomes geography

Raghunātha's place-prayers make the same inner orientation geographical.

To Govardhana he repeats a single request: *nija-nikaṭa-nivāsaṁ dehi govardhana tvam* — “O Govardhana, grant me residence near you.” In the tenth verse he explicitly says that Śacīnandana, without considering his fitness, has entrusted him to Govardhana.

At Rādhā-kuṇḍa the refrain narrows further: *rādhā-kuṇḍam evāśrayo me* — “Rādhā-kuṇḍa alone is my shelter.” The fifth verse names the desired flower of that shelter as *mad-īśā-dāsyā*, service to “my Mistress.”

These themes have already been developed in the biography's residence chapter. Here they matter for a different reason: the places around which Raghunātha physically organized his final decades are the same places around which his poetry organizes desire.

The outer map and the inner map coincide.

### Not only lament: the poet of play

Raghunātha's literary personality would still be distorted if we stopped with viraha.

He also wrote extended līlā literature filled with wit and social play.

Bhakti-ratnākara remembers three principal works of Dāsa Gosvāmī: his collection of stotras, known as *Stavāvalī*, a *dāna-carita*, and *Muktā-carita*. The *dāna* work is identified in the later published tradition as *Dāna-keli-cintāmaṇi*.

*Dāna-keli-cintāmaṇi* develops the familiar toll pastime at Govardhana: Kṛṣṇa and His friends obstruct Rādhā and the gopīs and demand a tax. The poem is built from clever argument, teasing, resistance, glances and verbal combat. Its opening explicitly places the work under the mercy of Rūpa Gosvāmī.

*Muktā-carita* turns to the pearl pastime. Kṛṣṇa asks the gopīs for pearls, plants pearls of His own, produces a miraculous pearl crop and draws Rādhā and Her companions into an escalating exchange. The work is playful, dramatic and socially textured.

These are not marginal curiosities beside the “serious” Raghunātha. They show what his renunciation made room for: sustained imaginative absorption in Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa līlā.

The early pilgrimage tradition even uses his literature as a guide to landscape. Bhakti-ratnākara has Rāghava Paṇḍita point out Mālyahāri-kūṇḍa to Śrīnivāsa and direct him to Raghunātha's *Muktā-carita* for the corresponding pearl pastime.

The poet had become a way of seeing Vraja.

### The shape of the man behind the poems

Taken together, Raghunātha's writings resist every simple description of him.

He is the rescued heir who remembers wealth as a forest fire. He is the disciple who never ceases to name Svarūpa. He is the follower who binds his mind to Rūpa and Sanātana. He is the ascetic who begs his own mind to abandon pride. He is the resident of Govardhana and Rādhā-kuṇḍa who asks not merely to stay in a holy place, but to enter a world of service. He is the dāsī crying for Rādhā. And he is the poet who can still delight in the jokes, quarrels, tolls and pearl gardens of the Divine Couple.

His austerity is therefore best understood from the inside out.

He did not empty his life because emptiness was holy.

He emptied it because, in his poetry, something else had become overwhelmingly full.

## The Elder at Rādhā-kuṇḍa

### *The next generation comes to him*

Raghunātha had come to Vraja intending to end his life. Decades later, younger Vaiṣṇavas came to Rādhā-kuṇḍa because his life had become a place from which they sought direction.

That reversal is one of the quietest transformations in his biography.

He never became an institutional leader in the ordinary sense. He did not build a court around himself or replace renunciation with administration. Yet the early Vraja memory preserved in Bhakti-ratnākara repeatedly places him inside a senior circle whose blessing, permission and presence mattered to the next generation.

By then the body was weakening. The authority was not.

### *Śrīnivāsa is sent to the elders*

One of the clearest examples comes before Śrīnivāsa Ācārya's formal period of study.

Jīva Gosvāmī does not simply begin teaching him and leave the wider Vraja community outside the process. Bhakti-ratnākara remembers Jīva sending Śrīnivāsa to the senior circle at Śrī-kūṇḍa. There he meets Raghunātha dāsa, Rāghava Paṇḍita, Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja and others.

Śrīnivāsa remains at Rādhā-kūṇḍa and Govardhana for three days. Only after receiving the permission and grace of that circle does he return to Vṛndāvana, where his formal study proceeds.

*Rāghava, Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja and the others bestowed their fullest grace upon Śrīnivāsa. After remaining three days at Rādhā-kūṇḍa and Govardhana, he took everyone's permission and returned to Vṛndāvana.*

The passage should not be forced into a modern institutional model. This was not an academic admissions committee. But neither is it casual courtesy.

The route itself is meaningful: Jīva in Vṛndāvana sends the younger student outward to the Rādhā-kūṇḍa elders, and the student returns after receiving their blessing.

Raghunātha had once been the younger man placed under Svarūpa. He had once been the grieving newcomer kept alive by Rūpa and Sanātana. Now he belonged to the generation from whom another student received permission before moving forward.

### *“Residence at Rādhā-kūṇḍa comes through Raghunātha's mercy”*

Bhakti-ratnākara later gives the relationship an even more concentrated formulation when Rāghava Paṇḍita guides Śrīnivāsa and Narottama around the kūṇḍas:

*“O Śrīnivāsa, know this certainly in your heart: residence at Rādhā-kūṇḍa comes through the mercy of Raghunātha.”*

The statement belongs to Narahari Cakravartī's later devotional historiography, not to Raghunātha's own mouth. But it is valuable evidence for how the early pilgrimage community remembered him.

His identity had become inseparable from three forms of sevā that Rāghava immediately names together: Śrī-kūṇḍa, the Govardhana-śilā, and the guñjā garland.

The gifts Mahāprabhu had placed in his hands in Purī had become, in the memory of later pilgrims, the public signs by which his Vraja life was recognized.

### The old man rises to embrace them

The later visit of Śrīnivāsa and Narottama gives a more intimate picture.

They approach Raghunātha and fall to the ground at his feet. Narahari emphasizes how weak his body has become. Yet Raghunātha rises.

*“Although Gosvāmī’s pure body was exceedingly weak, he rose and extended both arms. He embraced Śrīnivāsa and Narottama.”*

The gesture is easy to miss because later biographies naturally dwell on his physical austerity. Here his weakness is present, but it serves as contrast.

He stands because they have come.

Raghunātha’s mature authority is therefore not cold distance. The next generation encounters touch, tears, blessing and embrace.

Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja appears in the same Rādhā-kunḍa circle. This matters because Kṛṣṇadāsa’s relationship with Raghunātha is not merely a late claim attached to a famous author. In Caitanya-caritāmṛta he says autobiographically that through mercy he attained Raghunātha and through Raghunātha attained the shelter of Svarūpa. Elsewhere he explicitly identifies Raghunātha as the human conduit through whom Svarūpa’s treasury of Caitanya-līlā reached him.

At Rādhā-kunḍa, the transmission line described in the text had a living social setting.

### Rāmacandra Kavirāja

The same pattern appears when Rāmacandra Kavirāja comes to Āriṭa.

After bathing in Rādhā-kunḍa and Śyāma-kunḍa, he approaches Raghunātha and bows. Raghunātha embraces him affectionately. The narrative later notes Raghunātha’s appreciation of Rāmacandra’s ability to compose verses.

Again, the episode need not be enlarged into Rāmacandra’s biography. What matters here is the recurring shape of encounter: younger Vaiṣṇavas come to the kunḍa, bow to the aged Gosvāmī, and are personally received.

Raghunātha’s literary sensitivity also remains visible. The author of Vilāpa-kusumāñjali and Mukta-carita recognizes poetry in another devotee.

### Jāhnavā comes because he can no longer go

The meeting with Jāhnavā Īśvarī belongs still later in the portrait and makes Raghunātha’s age unmistakable.

Bhakti-ratnākara presents him explicitly as residing at Rādhikā-kunḍa when news reaches him that Jāhnavā has come to Vraja. He desires to see her, but age, renunciation and the force of separation have weakened him so severely that he cannot make the journey.

The direction of pilgrimage reverses.

Jāhnavā comes to him.

Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja and other devotees carry messages between the two circles. When she finally reaches Rādhā-kuṇḍa, Kṛṣṇadāsa goes ahead to tell Raghunātha that she has arrived.

Narahari's account then describes Raghunātha coming forward in tears. Jāhnavā sees his emaciated body and his extraordinary devotional radiance, and the meeting becomes a scene of shared prema. The Vrajavāsīs of Āriṭa gather as well.

She remains at Rādhā-kuṇḍa for several days, cooking, making offerings and feeding Vaiṣṇavas and Vrajavāsīs.

For Raghunātha's biography, the important fact is not the full itinerary of Jāhnavā's pilgrimage. It is that the man who once crossed India almost alone to reach Mahāprabhu had become physically unable to travel, while the Gauḍīya world now traveled to him.

### What kind of authority was this?

Raghunātha's authority at Rādhā-kuṇḍa is difficult to name with a single modern word.

He was not merely a resident ascetic, because younger devotees sought his permission and mercy. He was not merely a teacher, because some of his greatest influence came through remembered life, affectionate encounter and transmitted līlā rather than classroom instruction. He was not merely a keeper of a sacred site, because his authority extended through literature, lineage memory and relationships reaching back to Svarūpa and Mahāprabhu.

Perhaps the simplest description is the one his life had earned: elder.

He had received from Haridāsa, Advaita, Nityānanda, Mahāprabhu, Svarūpa, Rūpa and Sanātana. At Rādhā-kuṇḍa, younger Vaiṣṇavas began receiving through him.

This is why the final years cannot be understood only as increasing bodily weakness.

His body was diminishing while his place in Gauḍīya memory was expanding.



## The Last Years

### *When only service remained*

Age did not arrive gently for Raghunātha.

By the time the younger generation was coming to Rādhā-kuṇḍa for his blessing, the losses behind him had accumulated almost beyond counting. Mahāprabhu and Svarūpa were gone from his sight. Sanātana, who had refused to let him die and later forced him to accept shelter beneath a roof, was gone. Rūpa, whom he had bound into his own daily remembrance, was gone as well.

Bhakti-ratnākara remembers Raghunātha and Gopāla Bhaṭṭa as living in the fire of separation after the disappearance of Rūpa and Sanātana.

For Raghunātha, viraha was no longer only a poetic theology. It had become the atmosphere of old age.

### The names he still cried

One late scene is especially revealing.

When Śrīnivāsa was preparing to leave Vraja for Gauḍa with the books of the Gosvāmīs, Jīva sent him to take leave of Dāsa Gosvāmī. The thought of another separation struck Raghunātha immediately.

Narahari describes him crying out the names of Svarūpa, Rūpa and Sanātana and rolling on the ground while tears streamed from his eyes.

Those three names contain the architecture of his mature life.

Svarūpa had formed him beside Mahāprabhu in Purī. Rūpa and Sanātana had kept him alive when he reached Vraja intending to die. Decades later, in the weakness of old age, those relationships had not become memories stored safely in the past. Separation from them remained present.

### A body almost unable to continue

Bhakti-ratnākara's description of his body becomes increasingly stark.

Raghunātha is said to have eaten only once every three or four days. He had become so weak that even a gust of wind was difficult to bear. After bowing fully to the ground, he sometimes lacked the strength to stand again.

The devotees asked him not to continue offering daṇḍavats in that condition.

He did not argue with them.

He simply continued.

This late portrait should not be turned into a regimen for imitation. The text is describing the extremity of one particular life, already shaped by decades of unusual renunciation, old age, grief and devotional absorption.

What matters biographically is that bodily incapacity did not redirect his attention toward himself.

### The gifts from Purī were still there

At precisely the point where Narahari's account makes Raghunātha seem physically most fragile, it tells us what remained in his hands.

The Govardhana-śilā.

The guñjā-mālā.

The gifts Mahāprabhu had personally given him in Purī were still objects of his worship.

*With great joy he worshiped the Lord through the Govardhana-śilā and the guñjā-mālā that had been given to him. Absorbed in that worship, he forgot even his own existence.*

The continuity is extraordinary.

In youth he had tried repeatedly to escape the house of wealth. In Purī, Mahāprabhu had placed Govardhana and Rādhā's shelter into his hands through the stone and garland. In Vraja, he had built his life beside Govardhana and Rādhā-kunḍa. Now, in extreme old age, when so many of the people who had shaped him were gone, those same gifts remained before him.

The object Mahāprabhu had wet with His own tears had outlasted nearly every human relationship around which Raghunātha's adult life had been formed.

Narahari continues by describing him absorbed in nāma-kīrtana, sometimes passing sleepless nights in tears, and remaining immersed in remembrance of Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa and Caitanya.

His final years therefore do not move away from the themes of his earlier life. They compress them.

### Blind, on his death bed, still thinking of Rādhā-kunḍa

The documentary record gives us a very different kind of late-life witness.

A Sanskrit settlement dated to 1584 survives in two reported copies. Tarapada Mukherjee and J. C. Wright published and analyzed the document. Its wording is unusually personal.

Raghunātha identifies himself as blind, as devoted to the service of Śrī Rādhā-kunḍa, and as dictating the document at the end of life. He places his property at the feet of the deity worshiped by Jīva — effectively transferring the foundation into the Rādhā-Dāmodara/Jīva custodial line.

*The document describes Raghunātha as a blind servant devoted to Rādhā-kunḍa and says that he is dictating it “on my death bed.”*

This is one of the strongest historical anchors in the entire late biography.

It does not tell us what he ate that day or who sat beside him. It does not describe a disappearance līlā. But it gives a fixed documentary horizon: by 1584 Raghunātha was blind, considered himself near death, and was making arrangements for the property attached to the service of Rādhā-kunḍa.

Even here, at the edge of death, the language returns to sevā.

### Why the disappearance year remains open

It would be convenient to end the biography with a single uncontested year.

The evidence does not allow that.

Later devotional chronologies give specific disappearance dates, and some modern biographies repeat them with confidence. The documentary material is more difficult.

The 1584 Sanskrit settlement explicitly speaks from a death-bed setting. Yet a Persian declaration dated 2 June 1588 records a hiba — a gift — of six plots near the tank to Jīva, in Raghunātha's name. That later document cannot simply be ignored. But neither can it be used mechanically to say, “therefore Raghunātha was certainly alive in 1588,” as though the relationship between the two documents were already solved.

The project's documentary work has identified real tensions among purchase dates, later registrations, retrospective statements and transfer records. The precise relationship between the 1584 settlement and the 1588 hiba still requires full collation of the surviving originals and copies.

For that reason, the strongest responsible conclusion is modest:

*Raghunātha is securely documented in a death-bed settlement in 1584. A 1588 legal record preserves a later property transfer in his name. The exact year of his disappearance remains unresolved.*

This uncertainty does not weaken the biography.

It protects it from false precision.

### What remained at the end

Raghunātha's late life can look, from outside, like a sequence of losses.

His teachers disappeared. His body failed. His eyesight was gone. Food diminished. Sleep diminished. Physical independence diminished.

Yet the sources do not leave us with emptiness.

They leave him chanting.

They leave him remembering Svarūpa, Rūpa and Sanātana.

They leave him worshiping the Govardhana-śilā and guñjā-mālā Mahāprabhu had placed in his hands.

They leave him concerned with the service and future custody of Rādhā-kuṇḍa.

The young heir of Saptagrāma had spent his life trying to escape possession. Near the end, the final legal act we can securely place in his own lifetime is an act of relinquishment.

He gives away what remained.

And the biography now reaches the place where prose history must yield to sacred memory: his disappearance, his samādhi at Rādhā-kuṇḍa, and what a pilgrim standing there should remember.

## At His Samādhi

*What a pilgrim should remember*

A biography naturally wants a final scene.

For Raghunātha dāsa Gosvāmī, the sources do not give us one that can be narrated with confidence.

We know the condition of his last years. We know that he had become blind and extraordinarily weak. We know that the names of Svarūpa, Rūpa and Sanātana still brought him to tears. We know that Mahāprabhu's Govardhana-śilā and guñjā-mālā remained in his worship. We know that in 1584 he dictated a settlement from what the document itself calls his death bed, still identifying himself through service to Rādhā-kuṇḍa.

What we do not securely possess is an eyewitness account of the precise moment in which he left this world.

So the biography should not manufacture one.

### The disappearance date

Living Gauḍīya traditions preserve disappearance dates and observe Raghunātha's tirobhāva with devotion. Those traditions belong in the record and should be honored as tradition.

Historically, however, the late documentary evidence remains difficult. The 1584 Sanskrit death-bed settlement is secure enough to provide a strong late-life horizon. A 1588 legal record also preserves a transfer in his name. Until the relationship between these documents is completely resolved, no single Gregorian disappearance year should be presented here as certain.

This is not a place where precision must be invented in order for devotion to remain meaningful.

The end of his life is historically indistinct. The place in which his life came to rest is not.

### The samādhi at Rādhā-kuṇḍa

The living Rādhā-kuṇḍa tradition venerates Raghunātha's samādhi in the sacred complex on the northern side of Rādhā-kuṇḍa, in association with his bhajana-kuṭīra.

Modern descriptions of the site record a samādhi-mandira there, and his disappearance day continues to be observed at the samādhi.

The present marble shrine and its architectural form belong to the later history of the site. The biography therefore should not claim that every visible feature is unchanged from the sixteenth century.

But as a place of Gauḍīya memory, the samādhi is the natural endpoint of Raghunātha's pilgrimage biography.

He had prayed: "Here alone shall be my residence; here alone shall be my abiding place." The tradition remembers him there still.

### Do not remember only the renunciation

A pilgrim approaching the samādhi can easily remember the spectacular things.

The wealthy heir who escaped without money. The twelve-day journey to Purī. The man who begged, then rejected even ordinary begging. The rice even the cows refused. The thousand daṇḍavats. The one lakh names. The body reduced almost to nothing.

All of that belongs to Raghunātha.

But none of it is the center.

The center is relationship.

### Haridāsa

Remember the boy who repeatedly went to Haridāsa Ṭhākura. Before the great renunciant existed, there was a child drawn toward a saint whose life was the holy name.

### Nityānanda

Remember Pānihāṭi. Raghunātha's door to freedom did not open through a private heroic escape plan. Nityānanda first made him serve the Vaiṣṇavas and receive their blessing.

### Mahāprabhu and Svarūpa

Remember that Mahāprabhu did not simply approve his renunciation. He entrusted Raghunātha to Svarūpa Dāmodara. For sixteen years Raghunātha learned to live near the most intimate currents of Caitanya's final līlā. His memory later became one of the channels through which that world reached Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja.

### Rūpa and Sanātana

Remember that Raghunātha came to Vraja intending to die at Govardhana. Rūpa and Sanātana would not let him. They accepted him as their own third brother. His Rādhā-kuṇḍa life exists on the other side of that mercy.

### Govardhana and the guñjā-mālā

Remember what Mahāprabhu placed in his hands: the Govardhana-śilā and the guñjā garland. Raghunātha understood them as residence at Govardhana and shelter at the feet of Śrī Rādhā. Decades later, in extreme old age, he was still worshiping those gifts.

### Rādhā-kuṇḍa

Remember that Rādhā-kuṇḍa was not merely where he retired. It was the place he repeatedly named as shelter, the place in which he asked to reside, the landscape of his mānasī-sevā, the place whose waters he served, and the community in which younger Vaiṣṇavas eventually came to him for blessing.

### Rādhā-dāsyā

Finally, remember the voice behind the austerity.

In Vilāpa-kusumāñjali, Raghunātha does not present himself as the greatest renunciant. He presents himself as a servant unable to live without her Mistress.

The verse immediately before his declaration that Rādhā-kuṇḍa will be his residence gives perhaps the simplest prayer with which to stand at his samādhi:

*tavaivāsmi tavaivāsmi  
na jīvāmi tvayā vinā |  
iti vijñāya devi tvam  
naya mām caraṇāntike || 96 ||*

*“I am Yours. I am Yours. I cannot live without You. Knowing this, O Devī, please bring me near Your feet.”*

Then comes the next verse:

*“Your own kuṇḍa is the eternal abode of You together with Your beloved. Here alone shall be my residence; here alone shall be my abiding place.”*

Those two prayers are a better epitaph for Raghunātha than a list of austerities.

He began life inside immense possession and spent decades relinquishing everything that could stand between himself and service.

At the end, the biography does not leave him as a man who possessed nothing.

It leaves him belonging completely.

### For the pilgrim

When you stand before Raghunātha dāsa Gosvāmī’s samādhi at Rādhā-kuṇḍa, there is no need to reproduce his austerities in imagination.

Remember the chain of mercy that formed him.

Remember the holy name learned in the shadow of Haridāsa. Remember Nityānanda’s feast.

Remember Svarūpera Raghu. Remember the Govardhana-śilā wet with Mahāprabhu’s tears.

Remember Rūpa and Sanātana refusing his death. Remember the old man rising from weakness to embrace younger Vaiṣṇavas. Remember the poet who said that without Rādhā’s mercy even Vraja itself had no meaning.

And then remember the prayer with which he chose his home:

Here alone shall be my residence.

That is where his story ends.

## The day

The living Gauḍīya calendar tradition observes Śrīla Raghunātha dāsa Gosvāmī's appearance on Māgha śukla pañcamī — Vasanta-pañcamī. The same tithi is also associated in Gauḍīya calendars with the appearances of Viṣṇupriyā Devī, Puṇḍarīka Vidyānidhi and Raghunandana Ṭhākura.

Source-critical note: this tithi is strong as living Gauḍīya observance, but the project has not yet recovered an early sixteenth-century biographical witness fixing Raghunātha's appearance to this lunar day. Preserve the distinction between living liturgical tradition and earliest historical documentation.

Working pilgrimage date: the current Vṛndāvana Vaiṣṇava calendar places Māgha śukla pañcamī on Thursday, 11 February 2027. Re-check the local Vraja pañjikā shortly before the pilgrimage because tithi observance follows the local lunar calendar, not a permanently fixed Gregorian date.

No special Raghunātha-specific fast is assumed in this guide. Follow the vrata or prasāda practice of your guru-lineage and the local Vaiṣṇava program rather than inventing an austerity in imitation of Raghunātha.

## What the day is for

The aim is not to spend the day admiring how little Raghunātha ate.

His life is better remembered as a chain of mercy: Haridāsa's association, Nityānanda's grace at Pānihāṭi, Mahāprabhu's acceptance, Svarūpa's shelter, the Govardhana-śilā and guñjā-mālā, Rūpa and Sanātana refusing his death, and finally his life of Rādhā-dāsyā at Rādhā-kuṇḍa.

On his appearance day, let the physical places around Rādhā-kuṇḍa become memory-points for that chain.

## A simple observance for the day

1. Begin quietly before the crowds and programs take over the day. Chant your normal morning japa. Add no heroic quota simply because it is Raghunātha's appearance day. The first offering is steadiness, not imitation.
2. At the beginning of the day, read a short life-summary rather than the whole eighteen-chapter biography. A good sequence is RDGB-01 or its childhood section, RDGB-04 on Pānihāṭi, RDGB-06 on Svarūpera Raghu, RDGB-08 on the Govardhana-śilā and guñjā-mālā, RDGB-12 on Rūpa and Sanātana, and RDGB-18 at the samādhi.
3. Go to Raghunātha's bhajana-kuṭīra and samādhi with no hurry. If a local kīrtana, kathā, pūjā, Vaiṣṇava-sevā or mahāprasāda program is taking place, allow the living observance to take precedence over your private schedule.
4. At the kuṭīra, remember Purī. This is the place to read Gaurāṅga-stava-kalpavṛkṣa 11, where Raghunātha himself remembers Mahāprabhu rescuing him from great wealth, placing him with Svarūpa, and giving the guñjā garland and Govardhana-śilā.

*mahā-sampad-dāvād api patitam uddhṛtya kṛpayā  
svarūpe yaḥ svīye kujanam api mām nyasya muditaḥ |  
uro-guñjā-hāraṁ priyam api ca govardhana-śilām  
dadau me gaurāṅgo hṛdaya udayan mām madayati || 11 ||*

*“By mercy He lifted even me, fallen into the forest fire of immense wealth; joyfully He placed this unworthy person with His own Svarūpa, and He gave me the dear guñjā garland from His chest and the beloved Govardhana-śilā. May that Gaurāṅga rise within my heart and intoxicate me.”*

5. At the samādhi, do not begin with a list of austerities. Begin with belonging. Read Vilāpa-kusumāñjali 96–97 slowly.

*tavaivāsmi tavaivāsmi  
na jīvāmi tvayā vinā |  
iti vijñāya devi tvam  
naya mām caraṇāntike || 96 ||*

*sva-kuṇḍam tava lolākṣi  
sa-priyāyāḥ sadāspadam |  
atraiva mama saṁvāsa  
ihaiva mama saṁsthitih || 97 ||*

*“I am Yours. I am Yours. I cannot live without You. Knowing this, O Devī, please bring me near Your feet. O restless-eyed one, Your own kuṇḍa is the eternal abode of You together with Your beloved. Here alone shall be my residence; here alone shall be my abiding place.”*

6. Then sit silently for a few minutes. A useful personal prayer is simple: ask for attachment to the holy name, shelter in genuine Vaiṣṇava relationship, freedom from self-display, and a particle of Raghunātha’s longing for service.
7. Approach Rādhā-kuṇḍa itself as the place Raghunātha called his shelter. Use the bathing and etiquette guidance already established in RKPG-01 rather than reproducing it here. If you take snāna, do so according to your lineage, health, local conditions and the established guide.
8. At the bank of Rādhā-kuṇḍa, read Rādhā-kuṇḍāṣṭaka 5. It tells you what the kuṇḍa meant to Raghunātha: service to the kuṇḍa culminates in the flower of service to his Mistress.

*api jana iha kaścid yasya sevā-prasādaiḥ  
praṇaya-sura-latā syāt tasya goṣṭhendra-sūnoḥ |  
sapadi kila mad-īśā-dāsya-puṣpa-prasasyā  
tad ati-surabhi rādhā-kuṇḍam evāśrayo me || 5 ||*

*“By the grace of serving this kuṇḍa, the celestial vine of love for the son of the lord of Vraja may arise and immediately become glorious with the flower of service to my Mistress. May that exceedingly fragrant Rādhā-kuṇḍa alone be my shelter.”*

9. If you go to Girirāja the same day, carry one verse rather than a long reading list. Govardhana-vāsa-prārthanā-daśaka 10 is especially fitting because Raghunātha explicitly remembers that Śacīnandana entrusted him to Govardhana.



*nirupadhi-karuṇena śrī-śacīnandanena  
tvayi kapaṭi-śaṭho 'pi tvat-priyenārpito 'smi |  
iti khalu mama yogyāyogyatāṁ mām agrhṇan  
nija-nikaṭa-nivāsaṁ dehi govardhana tvam ||10||*

*“By the causeless mercy of Śrī Śacīnandana I, though deceitful and unfit, have been entrusted to you by one dear to you. Therefore, without considering whether I am qualified or unqualified, O Govardhana, please grant me residence near you.”*

**10.** End the day with Vaiṣṇava association and prasāda if available. Raghunātha’s decisive turning points repeatedly came through other devotees. A solitary observance that ignores the Vaiṣṇavas would miss something central in his life.

### A compact reading sequence

| Moment            | Reading                           | Why this reading                                                                      |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Morning           | RDGB-04 — Pānihāṭi                | Grace comes before escape; service to Vaiṣṇavas opens the door.                       |
| Late morning      | RDGB-06 — Svarūpera Raghu         | Mahāprabhu places him under Svarūpa rather than making him spiritually independent.   |
| At bhajana-kuṭīra | RDGB-08 — Govardhana in His Hands | The śilā and guṇjā-mālā connect Purī directly to his Vraja life.                      |
| At samādhi        | RDGB-12 + RDGB-18                 | Rūpa and Sanātana refuse his death; the life ends in belonging, not heroic isolation. |
| At Rādhā-kuṇḍa    | Rādhā-kuṇḍāṣṭaka 5 and 8          | Rādhā-kuṇḍa as shelter, daily līlā and Rādhā-dāsyā.                                   |
| Evening           | RDGB-15 — The Poet of Longing     | See what filled the inner world behind the outward vairāgya.                          |

### If you want only three prayers

If the day becomes crowded, emotional or physically tiring, do not turn the observance into a checklist. Three short texts are enough:

- Gaurāṅga-stava-kalpavṛkṣa 11 — remember who gave Raghunātha his life of renunciation and service.

- Rādhā-kuṇḍāṣṭaka 5 — remember the goal as mad-īśā-dāsyā, service to Rādhā.
- Vilāpa-kusumāñjali 96–97 — surrender and residence: “I am Yours” and “Here alone shall be my abode.”

## What not to imitate

Raghunātha’s severe fasting, minimal sleep and bodily neglect belong to his extraordinary individual life and are not the recommended way to honor his appearance day.

Do not create a new fast, reduce water, skip needed food, stay awake all night, or multiply daṇḍavats beyond your ordinary capacity merely to resemble him.

The safer and more faithful imitation is qualitative: simplicity, humility, nāma, gratitude for Vaiṣṇavas, attention to Mahāprabhu’s mercy, and longing for service.

## At the samādhī: a personal meditation

*Raghunātha, you were born into wealth but learned that mercy was greater than possession. Nityānanda made you serve the Vaiṣṇavas. Mahāprabhu gave you to Svarūpa. He placed Govardhana and Rādhā’s shelter in your hands. Rūpa and Sanātana would not let grief end your life. At Rādhā-kuṇḍa you turned that rescued life into service, memory, poetry and longing. Please let me remember your life without imitating what I am not qualified to imitate. Give me attachment to the holy name, dependence upon genuine Vaiṣṇavas, and a small desire to serve Śrī Rādhā at the feet of those who are dear to Her.*

## Practical field notes

- Local program first: if the samādhī or nearby Vaiṣṇava community announces appearance-day kathā, kīrtana, pūjā or prasāda, join respectfully rather than insisting on this private sequence.
- Keep RDGB-A01 on the phone as the short field document; keep RDGB-01–18 available for longer reading when sitting.
- Use RKPG-01 for Rādhā-kuṇḍa snāna, dress, water-contact and etiquette details; do not rely on this appendix as the bathing guide.
- Use RKPG-02 for additional prayers to Rādhā-kuṇḍa, Govardhana and the Divine Couple.
- Do not assume every current structure or marked spot is unchanged from Raghunātha’s lifetime. The samādhī and bhajana-kuṭīra are living sacred-memory sites; precise architectural continuity is a separate historical question.
- For 2027, re-confirm Māgha śukla pañcamī with the local Vraja calendar shortly before travel.

## Source and Chronology Note

Primary narrative anchors include Kṛṣṇadāsa Kavirāja's Caitanya-caritāmṛta and Raghunātha dāsa Gosvāmī's own Stavāvalī corpus, especially Gaurāṅga-stava, Manaḥ-śikṣā, the Govardhana prayers, Rādhā-kuṇḍāṣṭaka and Vilāpa-kusumāñjali. Bhakti-ratnākara is used as early Vraja/Gauḍīya devotional historiography rather than as a contemporary transcript.

The restoration of the twin kuṇḍas, the Pāṇḍava-tree tradition, Sanātana's kuṭīra intervention, and the Śrīnivāsa–Narottama encounter have been checked against the searchable Bengali/Romanized Bhakti-ratnākara witness. The Jāhnavā episode remains controlled through a complete working transcription/translation and is retained only as B-level paraphrase pending direct printed-Bengali collation.

Kavi Karṇapūra's Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā 186 principally names Rasa Mañjarī while explicitly preserving traditions that call Raghunātha Rati Mañjarī or Bhānumatī. The present biography preserves that plurality. Later equations involving Tulasī Mañjarī remain lineage/commentarial genealogy rather than an automatic primary-text substitution.

For full evidence maps, textual variants, bibliography, and unresolved archival desiderata, consult the Scholarly Master and Research Ledgers included in the final project archive.